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Cybersecurity: FM asks financial sector to be ‘exceptionally vigilant’

Without naming Anthropic’s Mythos, Sitharaman said artificial intelligence tools are making cyberattacks faster & more adaptive

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Saturday urged all entities in the financial sector to be ‘exceptionally vigilant’ on cybersecurity.

Without naming Mythos, the newly minted platform from leading AI company Anthropic, Sitharaman said artificial intelligence tools are making cyberattacks faster and more adaptive.

Such tools can also evade detection by deploying tactics like automated discovery of system vulnerabilities and malicious source-code interference, she added.

“... not just Sebi but all regulated entities will have to remain exceptionally vigilant. The tools of attack are evolving at high speed, and the tools of defence must evolve even faster,” Sitharaman said, speaking at the 28th foundation day event of the capital markets regulator.

The comments come amid heightened fears over the capabilities of Mythos, which has sent regulators and policy-makers scrambling around the world to understand the platform and ways to safeguard their systems.

The government had called a meeting of top bankers with



Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman

“THE TOOLS OF ATTACK ARE EVOLVING AT HIGH SPEED, AND THE TOOLS OF DEFENCE MUST EVOLVE EVEN FASTER”

ministers, including Sitharaman and IT minister Ashwini Vaishnav, in New Delhi on Thursday, where it announced the formation of a dedicated panel under SBI chairman C S Setty for the purpose.

On Saturday, Sitharaman warned that a single successful cyberattack on a major exchange, depository, or a large broker can disrupt markets on a national scale, erase wealth, and shake public confidence and urged Sebi to meet the emerging challenge of cybersecurity.

Highlights

- » ‘Not just Sebi but all regulated entities will have to remain exceptionally vigilant’
- » She warned that a single successful cyberattack on a major exchange, depository, or a large broker can disrupt markets on a national scale
- » Sitharaman urged Sebi to institutionalise a system of periodic consultation with its peers across the world

Sitharaman urged Sebi to institutionalise a system of periodic consultation with its peers across the world, making it clear that Indian regulations must not imitate other countries.

In comments made amid unease over foreign flows, Sitharaman said that such dialogue between regulators can give confidence to global capital.

“The more SEBI’s frameworks are understood abroad, the greater the confidence of global capital in Indian markets, and the greater the weight

SEBI carries in global rulemaking,” she said.

Sitharaman also exhorted the financial system to progress towards the goal of common know your customer (KYC) across all functions.

“It is the shared responsibility of all stakeholders to ensure that no citizen has to repeat the same verification journey across multiple financial products and platforms,” she said, urging Sebi to help drive the prescription of common KYC norms.

On the regulations front, the FM pitched for a soft-touch, public consultation-based approach to form principles-based rules rather than “overly detailed rulebooks”.

There is a need for regulations to not be restrictive, and be more sophisticated and anticipatory rather than merely reactive, the FM said.

Sitharaman said Sebi’s recent actions against unregistered ‘fininfluencers’ should be seen as the regulator’s seriousness to crack down against unlicensed financial advice, and underlined the need for more efforts on financial education.

“... we should not tolerate the monetisation of uninformed retail investor trust for personal enrichment,” she added.

With progress in technol-

ogy, there is an explosion of fake investment videos and apps circulating on social media, many of them using deepfake AI to impersonate leaders, she noted.

The minister asked Sebi to “invest very substantially” in public awareness, through campaigns on every major platform in regional languages, and through rapid-response take-down mechanisms for fraudulent content impersonating public officials.

There is a need for investor protection to evolve from a “defensive function into a developmental function”.

A “serious push” is required to make municipal bonds a more effective platform for raising money, she said, adding that urban infrastructure cannot be financed by budgetary support alone.

On the corporate bond market front, she pushed for more to build a more effective credit enhancement architecture so that access to bond markets is not confined only to the highest-rated issuers.

“... we want better markets, not merely bigger markets. Size without integrity is fragility. Volume without investor protection is exploitation. Growth without governance is unsustainable,” Sitharaman said.

Paytm unaffected by PPBL action, biz continues strong momentum

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India’s leading payments app, Paytm (One 97 Communications Ltd), said the Reserve Bank of India’s action on Paytm Payments Bank Ltd (PPBL) has no financial or business impact on the company, reiterating that it does not have any material business arrangements or exposure with the banking entity.

In a regulatory filing, the Noida-based fintech major said PPBL operates independently, with no board or management involvement from Paytm.

As previously disclosed on March 1, 2024, the company does not have any exposure to PPBL or any material business arrangements with PPBL.

No services provided by the company are in partnership with PPBL.

Additionally, PPBL operates independently, with no board or management involvement from the company.

Paytm also added that there is no financial impact on the company, since it had already impaired its investment in PPBL back in March 31, 2024.

There is no direct financial impact on the company since, as previously disclosed, the company had already impaired its investment in PPBL as of March 31, 2024, it said.

It further clarified that none of its services are linked to PPBL and that all its offerings, including those by its subsidiary, continue to function normally.

As informed earlier, Paytm



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(One 97 Communications Limited) and its services, which have been operating without interruption, will continue to operate uninterrupted.

These include the Paytm app, Paytm UPI, Paytm Gold and all other services offered by its subsidiaries and associated companies such as Paytm QR, Paytm Soundbox, Paytm card machines, and Paytm Payment Gateway, Paytm Money among others, added Paytm.

Paytm also emphasised that the matter relates solely to PPBL and should not be attributed to the company.

Over the past couple of years, Paytm has been doubling down on its core revenues, and has delivered three consecutive quarters of profit in FY26,

signalling a robust operating model.

To be sure, Paytm reported a profit after tax of Rs 559 crore. Adjusting for a one-time Rs 190 crore charge related to a loan to its joint venture, Paytm First Games, profit after tax still stood at a sizable Rs 369 crore.

In the December quarter, Paytm reported a profit after tax (PAT) of Rs 225 crore, an improvement of Rs 433 crore year-on-year.

EBITDA for the quarter improved to Rs 156 crore with an EBITDA margin of 7 per cent, reflecting an improvement of Rs 379 crore year-on-year driven by revenue growth and continued operating leverage.

Contribution profit stood at Rs 1,249 crore, up 30 per cent YoY with a contribution margin of 57 per cent, an improvement of 5 percentage points YoY.

Paytm UPI also continued to gain market share for the third consecutive quarter. Paytm’s consumer UPI GMV grew 35 per cent in the last nine months versus industry GMV growth of 16 per cent, the company had said during its Q3 FY26 results.

This has led analysts to recalculate their outlook, with recent brokerage coverage highlighting Paytm as one of the few fintechs with superior margin profile, driven by its increasing mix of high-margin merchant payment revenues and financial services distribution.

India Cements Q4 profit jumps fourfold to ₹59 crore

NEW DELHI: The India Cements Ltd (ICL) on Saturday reported over four-fold jump in consolidated net profit at Rs 59.5 crore for March quarter FY26, helped by an increase in volume and sales realisation.

ICL had logged a profit of Rs 14.67 crore in January-March FY25, helped by asset sales, according to a BSE filing.

ICL is a subsidiary of UltraTech Cement, an Aditya Birla group firm.

Revenue from operations was up 2.6 per cent to Rs 1,228.65 crore in March quarter FY26. Total expenses were at Rs 1,174.79 crore, down 10.5 per cent year-on-year.

In Q4, domestic sales volume was 3.12 million tonne, recording a growth of 18 per cent year-over-year, as per an earnings presentation by the company.

Net realisation had a 3.5 per cent increase quarter-on-quarter and 6.2 per cent rise year-on-year. Total income in the March quarter was at Rs 1,254.50 crore, up 2.57 per cent.

In entire FY26, ICL narrowed its loss at Rs 67.25 crore from Rs 143.69 crore a year ago. Total consolidated income was at Rs 4,572.35 crore, up 5.33 per cent.

Over the outlook, ICL said it has a capex plan of Rs 2,000 crore over next two years, where it will invest in growth opportunities and efficiencies. PFI

Textiles and garment exports fall 2.2% to \$35.8 billion in 2025-26

Only handicrafts grew slightly by 1.5% during the fiscal

NEW DELHI: The country’s textiles and garment exports fell 2.2 per cent to \$35.8 billion in 2025-26 due to contraction in shipments of key segments such as cotton, think tank GTRI said on Saturday. In rupee terms too, the exports fell 2.1 per cent during the last fiscal.

GTRI said the declining pattern is visible across major segments — cotton textiles (-3.9 per cent), ready-made garments (-1.4 per cent), and carpets (-5.3 per cent). Only handicrafts grew slightly by 1.5 per cent during the fiscal. The contrast between INR and USD growth highlights a deeper structural concern, the Global Trade Research Initiative (GTRI) said.

Its founder Ajay Srivastava

‘The declining pattern is visible across major segments - cotton textiles (-3.9%), ready-made garments (-1.4%), & carpets (-5.3%)’

said India is exporting more in value terms domestically, but earning fewer dollars globally.

For instance, man-made textiles show a 3.6 per cent rise in INR (Indian Rupee) but a 0.8 per cent decline in dollar terms, and garments show a 2.9 per cent INR increase despite

a 1.4 per cent dollar contraction, he said.

This suggests that currency depreciation and not competitiveness is behind the apparent growth, he said adding in real terms, India is losing market share or failing to expand in key global markets, particularly in labour-intensive sectors where it should be gaining ground.

He added this “raises a critical policy question: why are ongoing reforms not translating into export growth? Despite initiatives on production-linked incentives, logistics improvements, and trade facilitation, the data shows stagnation or decline in core segments. The government must urgently investigate bottlenecks”. PFI

AAI’s electronics engineers body flags concern over proposed privatisation of ATC services

MUMBAI: ATSEPA, an electronic engineers’ body at Airports Authority of India (AAI), has raised concerns over the proposed privatisation of air traffic control (ATC) services, saying that shifting control away from the Authority without establishing an autonomous regulatory entity could be perceived as a policy decision that weakens India’s national strategic capabilities.

In a letter to Civil Aviation Minister K Ram Mohan Naidu on April 23, Air Traffic Safety Electronic Personnel Association (India) General Secretary YP Gautam said the matter warrants urgent reconsideration at the highest policy level.

“The proposal to introduce private participation in Air Traffic Control services, without first operationalising



an independent Air Navigation Services (ANS) structure, is viewed with grave concern,” he said.

Stating that the matter is not exploratory, he said the carving out of ANS (ATC + CNS) from AAI has already been “deliberated, accepted in principle, and partially implemented” during the tenure of (late AAI Chairman) Guru Prasad Mohapatra.

Alleging that the rollback of that framework has resulted in

the present structural inconsistency, he said, “Proceeding with privatisation in the absence of an autonomous ANS entity will be perceived as a policy decision that weakens an existing national capability rather than strengthening it”.

Creating a system where ANS remains a dependent internal unit while competing with private entities will be seen as institutional disadvantage by design, the association said.

Fragmentation of ATC services in a safety-critical domain raises serious questions of accountability, uniformity, and operational integrity, it added.

The association also warned that “ignoring an already available, trained, and proven ANS workforce in favour of external providers risks avoidable

dilution of sovereign expertise”.

Seeking immediate operationalisation of ANS as an independent entity with full functional, financial, and administrative autonomy, prior to going ahead with the privatisation, ATSEPA said the entity should be enabled to provide ATC and CNS services to all airports on a non-discriminatory and competitive basis.

“The role of AAI should be clearly redefined to avoid overlap and conflict of interest. It is necessary to state that any move to proceed otherwise will be viewed as structurally flawed and institutionally detrimental, and is unlikely to find acceptance among the professional community entrusted with maintaining the safety and efficiency of India’s airspace” it said. PFI

Peak power demand hits record high of 252.07 GW

NEW DELHI: India’s peak power demand hit a record high of 252.07 GW on Friday following an intensifying heat wave, which pushed up the use of cooling devices like air conditioners and desert coolers, according to the latest power ministry data. The previous record high of 250 GW peak power demand was recorded in May 2024.

The country’s peak power demand was recorded at 252.07 GW, an all-time high, on April 24, higher than 240.12 GW on April 23, 2026, the power ministry data showed. The highest electricity supply on April 22 was recorded at 239.70 GW.

The power ministry had earlier projected a peak power

demand, the highest supply in a day, of 270 GW for this year’s summer season, but the actual demand met was well below the estimate. Last year in the summer season, the peak power demand was 242.77 GW, which was recorded in June, 2025.

In the first fortnight of this month, the peak power demand remained lower than the 235.32 GW recorded in April 2025.

Experts are of the view that the demand and consumption of electricity may further rise due to increase in intensity of heat wave conditions with more frequent use of air-conditioners, air coolers & other appliances by domestic as well as commercial consumers to beat rising mercury levels in the country. PFI

KIIT ranked 6th best university in India in THE Asia Rankings 2026

BHUBANESWAR: KIIT-DU has secured the 6th position among all universities in India, across both government and private institutions, in the Times Higher Education (THE) Asia University Rankings 2026.

The university has also emerged as the top-ranked institution not only in Odisha but across the entire eastern region of India. In 2025, the University was ranked 8th best in the country.

Globally, KIIT has climbed to the 169th position in Asia, marking a steady and impressive rise from 196th in 2024 and 184th in 2025.

The THE Asia University Rankings 2026 assessed 929



universities from 36 countries based on rigorous performance indicators across five key areas: teaching (learning environment), research environment (volume, income and reputation), research quality (citation impact, strength, excellence and influence), international outlook (staff, students and research), and industry

income (knowledge transfer and patents). The ranking is a major achievement for KIIT, as it has outperformed many established and legacy institutes despite being a young university.

The Founder of KIIT and KISS Dr Achyuta Samanta has hailed the ranking, stating that it demonstrates the sustained efforts and commitment of the faculty, staff and students towards achieving academic excellence.

He said that KIIT’s emphasis on internationalisation and innovation has helped it build a world-class academic ecosystem, reinforcing its position as a leading centre of higher education in India & beyond. MPOST

Scindia announces ₹2,500 cr defence plant of Adani in MP’s Kolaras

GUNA (MP): Union Communications Minister Jyotiraditya Scindia on Saturday announced a Rs 2,500 crore defence arms manufacturing plant of the Adani group in Kolaras area of his Guna parliamentary constituency.

The plant will generate around 2,000 direct jobs, Scindia said during a visit to Shivपुरi-Kolaras area.

It would come up within two months near Kolaras, about 70 km from here, at the junction of Kota Highway and Mumbai-Gwalior Highway, and address the



long-pending demand of industrial development, the minister said.

“Kolaras, known for agriculture and tomato production, will now emerge as an important centre of the country’s defence strength,” he stated. PFI

IDFC First Bank March quarter profit rises by 5% to ₹319 crore

Bank’s total income rose to Rs 12,183 cr during Q4 FY26

NEW DELHI: IDFC First Bank on Saturday reported a marginal 5 per cent rise in net profit to Rs 319 crore for Q4 FY26. The bank had earned a net profit of Rs 304 crore in Q4 FY25.

The lenders’ total income increased to Rs 12,183 crore during the quarter against Rs 11,308 crore in the same quarter a year ago, the bank said.



The interest income increased to Rs 10,553 crore for the reporting quarter, as against

Rs 9,413 crore in the same quarter a year ago.

On the asset quality front, the bank’s gross non-performing assets ratio improved marginally to 1.61 per cent against 1.87 per cent a year ago. Similarly, its net NPAs, or bad loans, came down to 0.48 per cent from 0.53 per cent in Q4 of previous year. PFI

RBL Bank Q4 profit triples to ₹230 cr as provisions decline

In the full financial year 2025-26, the bank’s net profit jumped 18 per cent to Rs 822 crore

MUMBAI: RBL Bank on Saturday said its March quarter FY26 standalone net profit more than tripled to Rs 230 crore aided by lower provisions and improvement in asset quality.

The private sector bank logged a profit of Rs 69 crore in the year-ago period. In the full financial year 2025-26, net profit jumped 18 per cent to Rs 822 crore.

Core net interest income (NII) grew 7 per cent on-year

CLOSER LOOK

- » ‘Core net interest income grew 7% on-year to Rs 1,671 crore in Q4 FY26 against Rs 1,563 crore a year ago’
- » However, the bank’s net interest margin contracted to 4.41% from 4.89% a year earlier & 4.63% from Q3
- » Provisions fell 14 per cent to Rs 678 crore in the quarter, helping operating profit rise 11 per cent to Rs 955 crore

to Rs 1,671 crore in January-March FY26 compared with Rs 1,563 crore a year ago, a state-

tracted to 4.41 per cent from 4.89 per cent a year earlier, and 4.63 per cent from December quarter.

Provisions fell 14 per cent to Rs 678 crore in the quarter, helping operating profit rise 11 per cent to Rs 955 crore.

On the asset quality front, the bank reported continued strengthening in its loan book. Gross non-performing assets (GNPA) ratio improved to 1.18 per cent at the end of March

said. However, the bank’s net interest margin (NIM) con-

2026 from 2.60 per cent a year earlier.

Commenting on the outlook, MD and CEO R Subramaniakumar in an earnings call said the lender expects growth momentum to continue in the current financial year, subject to economic conditions. “Our plan for the growth, if all other economic conditions and environment conditions remain, we will see the similar growth in FY27 also,” he said. PFI



CITY: Pg 5

BJP fires 'Sheesh Mahal 2' salvo



NATION: Pg 7

Shah says BJP will win 110 seats in Bengal phase 1



FILM: Pg 14

'I refuse to play by-stander in a story'

'IRAN CAN CALL US ANYTIME': TRUMP AFTER CANCELLING TOP OFFICIALS' PAK TRIP

Talks in limbo: US skips, Iran FM leaves

ASSOCIATED PRESS

ISLAMABAD: President Donald Trump says he told top US envoys not to travel to Pakistan to negotiate with Iran, telling Fox News that "they can call us anytime they want."

In a brief phone interview Saturday, Trump told Fox News that he told US negotiators Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner "you're not going to be making any more 18 hour flights to sit around talking about nothing." Trump also said of the US side "we have all the cards."

His comments came after the White House said Friday that Witkoff and Kushner would be heading to Pakistan for another round of negotiations with Iran.

Meanwhile, Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi left Pakistan on Saturday evening, two Pakistani officials told The



In this photo provided by the Pakistan Ministry of Foreign Affairs, Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi, center, is greeted by Pakistan Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar, second right, and Army Chief Field Marshal Asim Munir, third left, upon his arrival at Nur Khan airbase in Rawalpindi, Pakistan

Associated Press.

He met Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, Army Chief

Field Marshal Asim Munir and other senior officials, the officials said. They spoke on condi-

tion of anonymity because they were not authorised to speak to the media.

Aragchi's visit comes amid regional tensions and efforts by Islamabad to facilitate a sec-

TENSIONS PERSIST

» Trump told Fox News that he told US negotiators Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner 'you're not going to be making any more 18 hour flights to sit around talking about nothing'

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» Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi left Pakistan on Saturday evening

» He met Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, Army Chief Field Marshal Asim Munir and other senior officials

» Araghchi's visit comes amid regional tensions and efforts by Islamabad to facilitate a second round of talks between the United States and Iran

ond round of talks between the United States and Iran.

Senior Pakistani officials were present at an airport near Islamabad to see him off, two officials said, speaking on condition of anonymity because they were not authorised to speak to the media.

According to a PTI report, Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi met Pakistan's top civil and military leaders on Saturday and discussed the regional situation and the ongoing peace dialogue with the US, as the prospects for a second round of US-Iran talks this week appear to be diminishing.

Aragchi, who arrived in Islamabad late on Friday, met Pakistan's Chief of Defence Forces Field Marshal Asim Munir on Saturday, the Iranian Embassy in Pakistan said on X, but did not provide details about their discussions.

Continued on P6

New minds, new Niti



Prime Minister Narendra Modi exchanges a handshake with newly-appointed Vice Chairman of Niti Aayog Ashok Kumar Lahiri

Lahiri named V-C, new team on board

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The government has reconstituted the Niti Aayog, appointing former chief economic advisor Ashok Kumar Lahiri as vice chairman and five full-time members, including economist K V Raju, Director of AIIMS M Srinivas and Abhay Karandikar, Secretary, Department of Science and Technology.

Making the announcement, Prime Minister Narendra Modi wished a productive and impactful tenure to Lahiri and the new full-time members, including scientist Gobardhan Das and former cabinet secretary Rajiv Gauba.

"The Government has reconstituted the NITI Aayog. My best wishes to Shri Ashok Kumar Lahiri Ji on becoming the Vice Chairman. My best wishes also to Shri Rajiv Gauba Ji, Prof. K. V. Raju Ji, Prof. Gobardhan Das Ji, Prof. Abhay Karandi-

KEY POINTS

» Wishing all of them a productive and impactful tenure ahead: PM

» Lahiri is amongst India's most experienced and senior economists with a career spanning over four decades

» Currently a BJP MLA in West Bengal, he is a former chief economic advisor to the government of India and a member of the 15th Finance Commission

» The prime minister is the chairman of the Niti Aayog

kar Ji and Dr M. Srinivas Ji on becoming Full Time Members of NITI Aayog.

"Wishing all of them a productive and impactful tenure ahead," Modi said in a post on 'X'. Continued on P6

MALI ATTACKS: Forces engage, control claimed

Unidentified gunmen strike Capital

DAKAR (Senegal): Gunmen attacked several locations in Mali's capital and other cities early Saturday in a possible coordinated assault, residents and authorities said.

Mali's army said in a statement that "unidentified armed terrorist groups targeted certain locations and barracks" in Bamako and that soldiers were "engaged in eliminating the attackers."

It said in another statement later the situation was under control.

Mali has been plagued by insurgencies fought by affiliates of al-Qaida and the Islamic State group, as well as a separatist rebellion in the north.

An Associated Press journalist in Bamako heard sustained heavy weapons and automatic rifle gunfire coming from Modibo Keita International Airport, around 15 kilometres from the city centre, and saw a helicopter over nearby neighbourhoods.

COORDINATED ASSAULT

» Mali's army said in a statement that unidentified armed terrorist groups targeted certain locations and barracks in Bamako and that soldiers were engaged in eliminating the attackers

» It said in another statement later the situation was under control

The airport is adjacent to an air base used by Mali's air force. A resident living near the airport also reported gunfire and three helicopters patrolling overhead.

Residents in other cities in Mali reported gunfire and blasts on Saturday morning, suggesting a possible coordinated attack by armed groups.

Continued on P6

AAP to approach RS Chairman against rebels

Rebel camp fires back with corruption, ideology charges

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI/CHANDIGARH: Rattled by the defections of seven of its Rajya Sabha members, the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) on Saturday announced that it will seek their disqualification from the Upper House while the rebel group hit back, alleging

corruption and ideological decline in their former party.

The seven MPs, led by Raghav Chadha, who switched over to the ruling BJP also asserted that they have quit the party not out of fear but due to a growing sense of "disappointment, disengagement and disgust" with the existing leadership.

THE PARTY WILL WRITE TO THE RAJYA SABHA CHAIRMAN TO SEEK THE DISQUALIFICATION OF THE MPS FROM THE UPPER HOUSE

According to AAP sources, Punjab Chief Minister Bhag-

want Mann has sought time from President Droupadi Murmu for a meeting, along with party MLAs, to present the party's stand about the "recall" of the Rajya Sabha members who deserted the party on Friday. Six of the seven Rajya Sabha members who quit the AAP come from Punjab. Continued on P6

CHILD'S PLAY



Rajasthan Royals' Vaibhav Sooryavanshi was on fire against Sunrisers Hyderabad as he scored the third-fastest hundred in IPL history, off just 36 balls, in Jaipur, on Saturday

Alias life ends after 31 years

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police has arrested a 54-year-old man, who had allegedly been living under a false identity and was known locally as a social activist and YouTuber, in connection with a kidnapping-murder case from 31 years ago, an official said on Saturday. The

accused, identified as Salim Khan alias Salim Ahmed, also known as Salim Wastik, was apprehended from Loni in Uttar Pradesh by a team of crime branch. He had been evading arrest for over two decades after jumping from an interim bail granted in 2000, police said. See P5

INTENSE HEAT SWEEPS MULTIPLE REGIONS

IMD drops the heat manual



OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The India Meteorological Department (IMD) has issued a comprehensive heatwave advisory as several parts of the country reel under intense heat and above-normal temperatures.

The IMD said no major change in temperatures is likely over northwest India until April 27, after which a gradual dip is expected. Central and other regions may see fluctuations

during the forecast period. Stressing the need for preparedness, the weather office said early awareness and preventive measures are vital to reducing cases of heat exhaustion and heatstroke. Extended forecasts point to continued heatwave conditions over parts of the northwest, central and some southern regions over the next week.

Maximum temperatures across northwest, central and peninsular India are currently

MET ADVISORY

» Authorities have advised people to avoid prolonged exposure to the sun during peak afternoon hours, stay well-hydrated, wear light clothing and limit strenuous outdoor activity

» Extra caution has been urged for children, the elderly and those with pre-existing health conditions

DELHI ON BOIL AT 42.8 DEG C

NEW DELHI: The national capital sweltered on Saturday, recording its highest maximum temperature of the year so far. Several weather stations reported heatwave conditions across the city, even as the IMD has forecast rain from Monday to Wednesday, bringing some hope of respite to Delhiites. While a yellow alert had been issued for Saturday, a similar alert remained in place for Sunday as well, warning people of isolated heatwave conditions.

On Saturday, Safdarjung, representative of the city's weather, recorded a maximum Continued on P6



मेरी दिल्ली
नशा मुक्त दिल्ली

DELHI POLICE
SHANTI SEWA NYAYA

Committed to a Safer,
Drug-Free Delhi



MANAS

ANYTHING ABOUT NARCOTICS 24x7 1933

14446 24x7 HELPLINE FOR DE-ADDICTION

Website: www.ncbmanas.gov.in; Email: info.ncbmanas@gov.in

DRIVING COORDINATED ACTION AGAINST DRUG NETWORKS

Driven by a steadfast commitment, the Anti-Narcotics Task Force (ANTF), Crime Branch, Delhi Police, is working round the clock to stop drug networks and keep the city safe.

Operational Priorities

Enforcing NDPS Act | Intelligence | Interception and target networks | Coordinating with all stakeholders

On-Ground Action

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FOR IMMEDIATE POLICE HELP, CALL 112

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TALKS DELIVER NO PROGRESS ON KEY ISSUES; 1 KILLED IN RUSSIA

Russian attacks kill 5 in Ukraine’s Dnipro

KYIV: Russian drone and missile strikes on the Ukrainian city of Dnipro killed at least five people and wounded 46, authorities said Saturday.

The bodies of four people were found in the ruins of a house destroyed in overnight attacks, Dnipropetrovsk regional head Oleksandr Hanzha said.

“The Russians have been hitting Dnipro and other cities and communities practically all night,” Hanzha wrote on Telegram of the attacks, which caused fires to break out across Dnipro and partially destroyed several apartment buildings, businesses and a private house.

Another person was killed in a separate Russian attack on Dnipro Saturday afternoon, according to Hanzha, in the same residential area hit by the overnight strikes. He said that 46 people were wounded in total. To the southwest, two people were wounded in overnight drone attacks on the Odesa region. Residential buildings, port infrastructure



Rescue workers clear rubble of a residential building destroyed by a Russian strike, in Dnipro, Saturday AP

and cars were damaged in the south of the region, regional head Oleh Kiper said Saturday. In Russia, a woman was killed and a man was seriously wounded by a Ukrainian drone strike in the border region of Belgorod, local officials said. Following the overnight

attacks, Romania’s Defence Ministry said Saturday that drone fragments were found in a residential area of the south-eastern city of Galati, near the NATO member’s border with Ukraine. No casualties were reported. Romania has confirmed drone fragments on its

territory on multiple occasions.

The overnight attacks followed a prisoner swap Friday, in which Russia and Ukraine exchanged 193 service members.

Periodic prisoner exchanges have been one of the few positive outcomes of otherwise

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The bodies of four people were found in the ruins of a house destroyed in overnight attacks, Dnipropetrovsk regional head Oleksandr Hanzha said
- » ‘The Russians have been hitting Dnipro and other cities and communities practically all night,’
- » The attacks caused fires to break out across Dnipro and partially destroyed several apartment buildings, businesses and a house
- » Another person was killed in a separate Russian attack on Dnipro Saturday afternoon, according to Hanzha, in same residential area
- » He said that 46 people were wounded in total. To the southwest, two people were wounded in overnight drone attacks on the Odesa region
- » In Russia, a woman was killed and a man was seriously wounded by a Ukrainian drone strike in the Belgorod region

fruitless monthslong US-brokered negotiations between Moscow and Kyiv. The talks have delivered no progress on key issues preventing an end to Russia’s invasion of its neighbour, now in its fifth year. While meeting with Azerbaijani President Ilham Aliyev

on Saturday, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Ukraine is open to continuing peace talks with Russia in Azerbaijan.

“We have already held such talks — in Turkey and with our American partners in Switzerland,” he said. AGENCIES

Suspected Somali pirates hijack oil vessel

MOGADISHU: Suspected Somali pirates hijacked a fuel tanker off the northeastern coast of Somalia, according to a local official and the British military.

The vessel was seized on Wednesday in waters between the coastal towns of Hafun and Bandarbeyla in the semi-autonomous state of Puntland along the Indian Ocean.

The tanker had departed from the port of Berbera and was heading to the Somali capital of Mogadishu when it was intercepted, a colonel with the Puntland Maritime Police Force said. That official said six armed men from the Bandarbeyla district carried out the hijacking. The ship, owned by Pakistani interests and chartered by local businessmen, was carrying a large shipment of fuel.

B’desh issues nationwide security alert over possible militant attacks

DHAKA: Bangladesh Police issued a nationwide security alert over possible militant attacks on key installations, including the parliament complex, officials and media reports said on Saturday.

“The alert has been issued based on intelligence reports,” a police headquarters (PHQ) official said, requesting anonymity. The official described the alert as “urgent and confidential”.

A PHQ letter warned of possible coordinated attacks targeting the parliament complex, places of worship, entertainment facilities, and military and police installations, with armouries seen as potential targets, Bengali daily Prothom Alo reported.

The Daily Star and other newspapers said the alert was issued after the recent arrest of a banned militant outfit operative, Istiak Ahmed Sami alias Abu Bakkar, who was allegedly in contact with two dismissed military personnel.

TAKEAWAYS

- » The alert has been issued based on intelligence reports
- » The PHQ directed specialised police units to heighten vigilance

active, Istiak Ahmed Sami alias Abu Bakkar, who was allegedly in contact with two dismissed military personnel.

According to reports, the letter also included profiles of two alleged key planners behind the potential attacks, but did not name any organisation. It described the suspected perpetrators as “extremely dangerous for the overall security of the country”.

Quoting law enforcement officials, news portal tbsnews.net said the militant group could adopt multiple methods

to carry out attacks.

The PHQ directed specialised police units, including the Criminal Investigation Department (CID), Special Branch (SB), and Counter Terrorism and Transnational Crimes (CTTC) unit, to heighten vigilance, while regular police across the country have been asked to remain on high alert.

A police chief in a western district confirmed receipt of the letter, saying security measures had been stepped up in stations under his jurisdiction.

Bangladesh had witnessed an upsurge of extremist forces in the past 18 months during the Muhammad Yunus-led interim regime, following the ouster of deposed prime minister Sheikh Hasina’s Awami League government in August 2024 after a violent student-led street protest dubbed the ‘July Uprising’.

INTRODUCED IN CONGRESS

US: Bill seeks to pause H-1B visas

WASHINGTON: A group of Republican lawmakers has introduced a Bill in the US Congress for a three-year pause to the H-1B visa programme, contending that it has been hijacked to replace American workers with cheap foreign labour. Congressman Eli Crane from Arizona introduced the End H-1B Visa Abuse Act of 2026, which was co-sponsored by seven other Republican lawmakers.

The bill proposes reforms to the H-1B programme that include reducing the annual cap from 65,000 to 25,000 with a minimum wage of USD 2,00,000 per year and disallowing H-1B visa holders from bringing dependents to the US.

Congressmen Brian Babin, Brandon Gill, Wesley Hunt, Keith Self (all from Texas), Andy Ogles (Tennessee), Paul Gosar (Arizona) and Tom McClintock (California) have signed on as original cosponsors of the bill.

The H-1B visa programme is used extensively by American technology companies to employ foreign workers.

Indian professionals, including technology workers and physicians, form one of the largest groups of H-1B visa holders.

The bill seeks changes to the H-1B programme that include replacing the lottery system with a wage-based selection system; requiring employers to certify they cannot find a qualified American worker and have not conducted layoffs; barring H-1B workers from holding multiple jobs; and prohibiting third-party staffing agencies from employing them.

The bill also seeks to prohibit federal agencies from sponsoring or employing nonimmigrant workers; end Optional Practical Training (OPT); and ensure nonimmigrant visas remain temporary by prohibiting H-1B holders from adjusting status to permanent residency.

The changes suggested also require nonimmigrants to depart the United States before

INSIGHT

- » Congressman Eli Crane from Arizona introduced the End H-1B Visa Abuse Act of 2026, which was co-sponsored by seven other Republican lawmakers
- » They have sought a three-year pause to the H-1B visa programme

changing to another nonimmigrant status.

“The federal government should work for hardworking citizens, not the profit margins of massive corporations. We owe it to the American people to prevent the broken H-1B system from boxing them out of jobs they are qualified to perform,” Crane said.

He said the End H-1B Visa Abuse Act of 2026 would provide greater access to employment, strengthen protocols in the visa process, and prioritise the livelihoods of Americans.

“I am proud to cosponsor Rep Eli Crane’s efforts to reform and tighten our H-1B visa system, ensuring that our immigration system serves American workers first before foreigners,” said Rep Brandon Gill.

Rep Paul Gosar alleged that the H-1B programme has been “hijacked to replace American workers with cheaper foreign labour — plain and simple”.

The bill, he said, slams the brakes on a system that’s rigged against its own people and puts American jobs first again.

“If a company can hire an American, they should. No loopholes. No excuses. We’re done subsidising the outsourcing of our own workforce,” Gosar said.

Rep Andy Ogles said American workers are being replaced, and cheap foreign labour is the cause. “We will not bow down to the corporations, and we will not let Americans become strangers in their own country. End the H-1B scam,” he said. AGENCIES

Gaza mourns as pregnant woman, 2 children laid to rest

TEL AVIV: Palestinians on Saturday buried a pregnant woman with twins and two of her children who were among at least 13 people killed in Israeli strikes in Gaza.

The toll on Friday included two men who were killed in Gaza City, and eight others killed in the southern city of Khan Younis, according to local hospitals. Officials at Nasser Hospital in Khan Younis said the eight people, including four police officers, were killed after Israel targeted a police vehicle. Khalid Al-Tanani, of Beit Lahiyah, recalled the series of strikes that killed his wife and two of his four children in the northern Gaza Strip.

“With the first shell, thank God we all survived and were calling out to each other. Then they fired the second, third, and fourth shells one after the other. Their voices fell silent. I went inside and found my wife, Islam Al-Tanani, martyred, and my son, Hamza, and Naya in her mother’s arms. I found them martyred.” The children were 4 and 13 years old. Hamza’s 13-year-old twin survived, along with another of the couple’s children. Al-Tanani said they had just started talking about gathering baby items and clothes for the twins.

Family members wailed over the bodies on Saturday. “You took my soul with you, Hamza, you took me with

At least 13 people killed in latest Israeli strikes in Gaza

you and broke me, Hamza,” his grandmother sobbed. Israel’s military said several militants had threatened troops in the area and the military targeted them in an airstrike after warning civilians. Al-Tanani said the strikes came without prior notice.

Israel’s military said it had targeted two militants who threatened its troops in Gaza City and did not comment on the third strike in Khan Younis that killed eight. While the heaviest fighting has mostly subsided, deadly Israeli strikes have repeatedly disrupted the truce since it took effect on Oct. 10. The escalating Palestinian toll has prompted many in Gaza to say it feels like the war has continued unabated. Israeli forces frequently fire on Palestinians near military-held zones. Militants have carried out shooting attacks on troops, and Israel says its strikes are in response to that and other violations. Four Israeli soldiers have been killed since the ceasefire.

Israeli attacks have killed more than 790 people since the fragile ceasefire between Hamas and Israel was put in place six months ago. AGENCIES

Multiple illegal structures demolished in Kathmandu

KATHMANDU: Nepal’s Government on Saturday demolished hundreds of illegal structures built by landless settlers along the banks of the Bagmati River in the Thapathali and Gairegaun areas of Kathmandu.

The illegal structures were demolished under the joint efforts of the Federal Government, led by Balendra Shah, and Kathmandu Metropolitan City, with the help of the Armed Police Force, Nepal Police and Kathmandu Metropolitan Police personnel.

Some two dozen families of landless settlers, who were residing in the Thapathali area, have been shifted to temporary shelters at Dasharath Stadium in Kathmandu and Kirtipur Municipality, according to the police.

Around 146 families of landless settlers, residing in huts and temporary structures, were removed from the Thapathali area, while around 200 families were removed from the Gairegaun area, it added. AGENCIES

Trump has paused 3 Middle East wars, but grievances remain and could reignite them

Millions of people still displaced, and many fear the fighting could resume at any time

RAMALLAH: The post-Oct 7 order in the Middle East — such as it is — is barely pieced together by conditional ceasefires and mutual threats.

Iran has suffered severe blows, yet not enough to shake its posture at the negotiating table. Its allies Hezbollah in Lebanon and Hamas in Gaza are degraded but functioning, with Israel still regularly launching strikes at both. Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu is under mounting pressure to translate military achievements into clear dividends ahead of elections later this year.

US President Donald Trump, who boasts of his peace-making abilities, still appears to be seeking a nuclear deal with Iran and wider peace in the Middle East. But talks so far have produced no results and the two countries are locked in an escalating standoff over the Strait of Hormuz.

Major military operations have halted, but the underlying grievances — which long pre-date Hamas’ Oct 7, 2023, attack



— have not been addressed. Millions of people are still displaced, and many fear the fighting could resume at any time.

For weeks, Trump has vacillated between threats to unleash major attacks on Iran’s infrastructure — at one point threatening to end “a whole civilization” — and attempts to negotiate an agreement over its nuclear program and other disputes going back decades.

This week he extended a ceasefire but said he would maintain a U.S. naval blockade on Iranian ports. On Wednesday, he vowed to attack Iranian

fast boats in the Strait of Hormuz, which Tehran has effectively choked off since the start of the war, sparking a worldwide energy crisis.

Iran has given no public indication it is willing to make concessions on its nuclear program, ballistic missiles or support for regional proxies. It says the strait will remain closed until the US lifts its blockade and Israel halts attacks on Iran-backed groups like Hezbollah.

Neither side seems to want full-scale war and a new round of ceasefire talks was planned Saturday in Pakistan.

KEY POINTS

- » Trump, who boasts of his peacemaking abilities, still appears to be seeking a nuclear deal with Iran and wider peace in the Middle East
- » But talks so far have produced no results and the two countries are locked in an escalating standoff over Strait of Hormuz

A truce in Lebanon agreed to last week has largely held outside of the border area, where fighting continues. Israel has indicated it plans to occupy a swath of southern Lebanon indefinitely. The Iran-backed Hezbollah, which is not an official party to the truce, is demanding that Israel withdraw.

Trump announced a three-week extension of the truce on Thursday after a meeting between Israeli and Lebanese officials at the White House.

The US and Israel have demanded that Lebanon’s gov-

ernment assume responsibility for disarming Hezbollah. Beirut tried to enact part of a plan to do so before the outbreak of the latest fighting. But Lebanese leaders acknowledged their limited capacity, and their efforts yielded little as Hezbollah retained the ability to fire thousands of missiles and drones toward northern Israel over the past two months.

With Beirut unwilling to risk civil war by confronting the militants directly — especially while Israel occupies Lebanese territory — the ceasefire offers some reprieve.

A US-brokered ceasefire reached in October led to the release of the last remaining hostages held by Hamas and has halted major military operations. But Israel still carries out regular strikes against what it says are militant targets. Health officials in Gaza, seen as generally reliable by UN agencies and independent experts, have reported more than 790 Palestinians killed since last year’s ceasefire.

ica’s nuclear-powered Gerald R. Ford-class carriers, heightening speculation about whether a similar propulsion method will be used. In a further clue, pictures of the ship taken in February also showed structures that looked like nuclear reactor containment vessels, the Post report said.

Last November, China commissioned its third aircraft carrier, the Fujian, stated to be the most modern warship equipped with electromagnetic catapults, at a ceremony attended by Chinese President Xi Jinping. The Fujian is equipped with an electromagnetic aircraft launch system (EMALS) used only by the

American aircraft carrier USS Gerald R. Ford.

China was the last among the major countries to opt for aircraft carriers for its navy, years after the Indian navy began operating them.

China’s first carrier, the Liaoning, a refit of the Soviet-era ship, was commissioned in 2012, followed by Shandong, an indigenously built one in 2019.

Fujian has been commissioned after the military said carrier-based aircraft J-15T, J-35 and Kongfing-600 have successfully completed catapult-assisted take-off and arrested landing training on its flat deck. AGENCIES

World Briefs

PAKISTAN: NINE INJURED IN ATTACK BY UNKNOWN ASSAILANTS

PESHAWAR: Nine people were injured when unknown armed assailants opened fire on a police vehicle and an ambulance in Pakistan’s northwestern Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province on Saturday. The gunmen ambushed the police vehicle in the Rashkai area of Khar teshil, Bajaur district, injuring five police personnel, local police said. A rescue ambulance that arrived at the scene to take the injured to hospital also came under fire from the attackers, further escalating the situation. The ambulance driver and three civilians were also injured in the attack. Security forces have cordoned off the area and launched a search operation to apprehend those responsible.

GERMANY TO DEPLOY MINESWEEPER SHIPS TO MEDITERRANEAN

BERLIN: German Defence minister Boris Pistorius on Saturday said his country plans to deploy minesweeper ships to the Mediterranean, which later could be transferred to the Strait of Hormuz. “We will deploy a minesweeper to the Mediterranean and provide it with a command and supply ship,” Pistorius told the Rheinische Post newspaper Saturday. He did not say exactly when the ships are scheduled to depart. After an end to hostilities between the US, Israel and Iran, the German minesweepers could be deployed in the Strait of Hormuz, though such a mission would need to be approved by Germany’s Parliament.

BJP says Kejriwal spent private money; 'complete lies', AAP hits back

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AGENCIES



Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs
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INDIA'S PEAK POWER DEMAND HIT A RECORD HIGH OF 252.07 GW

Heatwaves, warm nights sear northern states; power demand hits record high

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The scorching heat, which has been slowly but steadily gripping northern states, showed no signs of abating, as the India Meteorological Department (IMD) released detailed guidelines and advisories on how to combat and survive heatwaves on Saturday, with Delhi logging its hottest day of the season, so far.

Temperatures in several regions have been significantly above normal — by five degrees Celsius or more — indicating a developing heat stress scenario across parts of the country, according to the IMD.

Meanwhile, India's peak power demand hit a record high of 252.07 GW on Friday

Highlights

- » Isolated areas in J&K, Himachal, Punjab, Haryana, Chandigarh, Delhi, UP, Rajasthan, and central India are expected to experience heatwave conditions and warm nights, the weather office observed
- » Uttar Pradesh was left reeling from soaring temperatures as Banda logged a scorching 47.4 degrees Celsius
- » In Rajasthan, Barmer recorded the highest temperature on Saturday, reaching 45.7 degrees Celsius, as temperatures hit sweltering levels in the state

following an intensifying heat wave, which pushed up the use of cooling devices like air conditioners and desert coolers, according to the latest power ministry data. The previous record high of 250 GW peak power demand was recorded in May 2024.

Isolated areas in Jammu and Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh,

Punjab, Haryana, Chandigarh, Delhi, Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan, and central India are expected to experience heatwave conditions and warm nights, the weather office observed.

On Saturday, Delhi recorded its highest maximum temperature of the year so far at 42.8 degrees Celsius, mark-

ing the highest maximum temperature in the city since 2022, when it reached 43.5 degrees Celsius on April 28.

IMD classifies a heatwave when at least two stations have met the required criteria.

An IMD official clarified that while Delhi had fulfilled the heatwave condition only in one station on Thursday, the two-step criteria are actually for the entire subdivision of Haryana-Chandigarh-Delhi.

"On Thursday, one station, Rohtak to be specific, of Haryana and Ridge of Delhi, had satisfied heatwave criteria, thus making it the first day. Saturday was the third consecutive day of heat waves," an IMD official said.

Uttar Pradesh was left reeling from soaring temperatures as Banda logged a scorching

47.4 degrees Celsius. This was followed by Prayagraj at 45.5 degrees Celsius and Varanasi at 45 degrees Celsius.

Similar blistering conditions were witnessed in Haryana and Punjab on Saturday, with Rohtak and Faridkot baking under the sizzling conditions.

Both states recorded above-normal maximum temperatures by up to six degrees. In Punjab, Faridkot recorded a day temperature of 45.2 degrees Celsius. In Haryana's Rohtak, the mercury settled at 44.6 degrees Celsius, according to the MeT.

In Rajasthan, Barmer recorded the highest temperature on Saturday, reaching 45.7 degrees Celsius, as temperatures hit sweltering levels in the state.

AMID PROTESTS

CM appeals to family of kids killed in Manipur blast to accept bodies

OUR CORRESPONDENT

IMPHAL: Manipur Chief Minister Y Khemchand Singh on Saturday appealed to the family of the two children killed in the bomb attack in Bishnupur district to accept their bodies, which have been in a morgue for over two weeks.

A 5-year-old boy and his 6-month-old sister were killed in the blast at Tronglaobi in Bishnupur district on April 7.

Their family members had said they would not accept the bodies until those responsible were arrested.

Addressing a press conference after a meeting with COCOMI representatives, Singh said the government was working with security agencies to trace those behind the attack.

"We are also in talks with the families of the deceased and the Joint Action Commit-



Security personnel arrive during a clash after thousands demanding permanent peace were stopped from marching towards the CM's residence, in Imphal, Saturday PTI

tee formed in connection with the incident. The state government is deeply pained that the bodies of the two children are in the morgue," he said.

Singh also called for dialogue and cooperation to restore peace in the state, saying prolonged shutdowns and unrest were affecting daily wage earners and students.

He described the killing of the children, along with a recent ambush in Ukhrul district in which two civilians were killed, as inhuman acts that had spread fear among people.

Earlier in the day, thousands of people under the banner of the Coordinating Committee on Manipur Integrity (COCOMI) staged protests in Imphal, demanding justice for the two children, rehabilitation of displaced people and permanent peace.

Protesters marching towards the chief minister's residence were stopped by security forces at several locations. In some areas, police used tear gas shells after demonstrators attempted to breach barricades, officials said.

Later, a delegation of protesters was allowed to meet the chief minister and submit a memorandum.

CJI Kant urges youth to cultivate strong character, acquire knowledge

OUR CORRESPONDENT

BHIWANI: Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on Saturday said the future of India rests in the hands of today's students and youth, urging them to cultivate strong character, acquire knowledge and become responsible citizens to help the country scale new heights.

Addressing the 5th convocation ceremony of Chaudhary Bansi Lal University, CJI Kant said academic degrees alone do not define success.

He said it is achieved through discipline, diligence, optimal use of time and a continuous willingness to learn.

Emphasising the broader purpose of education, Justice Surya Kant said it should

strengthen character, self-confidence and moral values rather than just ensuring employment.

Students' success should not be gauged solely by examination results; rather, one must observe the kind of citizens they have evolved into during the educational process, he remarked, adding that qualities such as integrity, sensitivity and a spirit of service are equally important as knowledge.

"Many young students describe their degree as a ticket to employment, to status, to a better life. And perhaps rightfully so. But tickets are useful only so far as it takes you from one place to another, because once that's done, their utility ceases to exist.

Crime scene recreated in rape-murder case of IRS officer's daughter; potency test conducted

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Crime scene recreation was carried out by investigators on Saturday at the southeast Delhi residence where the 22-year-old daughter of a senior IRS officer was allegedly raped and murdered on April 22, police sources said.

The investigators are working to piece together the exact sequence of events and have conducted a detailed mapping of the crime scene. They are also collecting "minute-to-minute" information regarding the accused, starting from Alwar, where he allegedly committed a rape, to the Delhi crime, the police sources said.

An iPhone stolen from the victim in Delhi has been recovered from a park, while a potency test of the accused

has been conducted as part of the rape investigation, they said. "Crime and forensic teams recreated the sequence of events inside the house for over two hours to establish how the crime unfolded. Every single minute detail has been recreated," the source said.

Access to the house was cordoned off, with a heavy police presence in and around the premises during the exercise.

The 22-year-old woman, an engineering graduate and UPSC aspirant, was fatally attacked at her residence in southeast Delhi's Kailash Hills locality on Wednesday morning.

Rahul Meena, who had been a domestic help at the residence but was fired over financial misconduct, used his familiarity with the house layout and access points to enter the flat. Citing

the investigation, sources said Meena was addicted to online betting and card games such as "teen patti" and had lost over Rs 7 lakh in the last few months, which drove him to frequently borrow money to sustain the habit. He had been spending his money on prostitution and used to watch porn videos on his mobile phone, besides gambling, they said.

He allegedly went to the rooftop study room where the woman was studying, attacked her with a heavy object, raped her and dragged her downstairs to use her fingers to open a biometric locker and steal cash.

The autopsy confirmed strangulation as the cause of death and found multiple injuries, including a nasal bone fracture, indicating a struggle.

"He fled after changing clothes and slippers, and

reached Palam Railway Station to catch a train to Rewari in Haryana. When he failed to catch the train, he booked a hotel in Dwarka, from where he was arrested. More than Rs 1 lakh in cash and stolen jewellery were recovered from his possession," a police officer said.

As part of the probe, the police took the accused to Palam railway station, where he had first gone after the crime, and will also take him to the Dwarka hotel where he stayed briefly before being arrested, sources said.

Investigations have also revealed that Meena was known for aggressive behaviour in his native village in Rajasthan and "During the inquiry, we came to know that Meena and his father were known in their village for their aggressive behaviour. Our team is there.

47 Maoist cadres surrender before Telangana Police

HYDERABAD: As many as 47 underground CPI (Maoist) cadres surrendered before the Telangana Police along with 32 firearms on Saturday, a top police official said.

The surrendered Maoists include Hemla lythu Alias Vijja, Dandakaranya Special Zonal Committee member and incharge of South Bastar Divisional Committee of CPI(Maoist), Telangana DGP B Shivadhar Reddy told reporters.

The 47 Naxals joined the mainstream as per the appeal made by Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy and after being attracted by the Telangana government's Surrender and Rehabilitation policy and the supportive approach of the state police, he said.

The 47 Naxals belong to Chattisgarh. The 32 firearms, include four AK 47 rifles, one

LMG (Light Machine Gun), three SLR rifles and 10 bundles (100 kg) of cordtex wire used in landmines.

Reddy said it could be the last of the major surrenders of Naxals and few of the remaining cadres may surrender in the future.

He said as many as 818 Maoists have surrendered before Telangana police since March 2024.

During the last two years, 334 weapons, including 58 AK 47 rifles, six LMGs, a US-made COLT rifle and an Israel-made TAVOR CQB weapon, were recovered from the Naxals.

Reddy said an investigation was underway to find how the Maoists got US and Israel-made weapons. While Telangana has already been declared Maoist-free, South Chattisgarh has almost become Maoist-free, he said.

AGENCIES

From Page 3

Talks in limbo...

The meeting, as shown in a brief video posted by the Iranian embassy on social media, was also attended by Iranian Deputy Foreign Minister Kazem Gharibabadi, Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baghaei, and Ambassador Reza Amir Mohadham.

Interior Minister Mohsin Naqvi and other officials were also part of the Pakistani side. "Araghchi met Munir in a formal huddle and discussed matters concerning peace talks with the US," a senior government official said.

The Iranian delegation later called on Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif and the two sides "reviewed bilateral matters as well as regional developments," the Iranian embassy said.

Pakistan's Deputy Prime Minister Ishaq Dar and Army chief Munir were also present at the meeting, where the two sides discussed the situation in the region, the prime minister's office said. "Araghchi seems to have conveyed 'certain concerns' of Iran to Pakistan, which Islamabad will share with the visiting US delegation upon its arrival. If the US agrees to placate these concerns and give some understanding, then the second round of direct talks will take place between them later in Islamabad," the official said.

Earlier, Iranian foreign ministry spokesperson Baqaei said that "no meeting" was planned to take place between Iran and the US during the visit of Araghchi, who will also travel to Oman and Russia. "Iran's observations would be conveyed to Pakistan," he said.

Araghchi, before leaving for Islamabad, on Friday said that he was embarking on a timely tour of Islamabad, Muscat, and Moscow, and the purpose of his visits is to "closely coordinate with our partners on bilateral matters and consult on regional developments. Our neighbours are our priority," he said. The first round of US-Iran talks held on April 11 and 12 failed to produce a breakthrough, prompting a flurry of diplomatic efforts by host Pakistan to cool tensions and revive hopes for another round of dialogue.

On Tuesday, Trump extended the two-week ceasefire with Iran indefinitely to give Tehran more time to prepare a unified proposal to end the war, just hours before the truce was set to expire. Meanwhile, large parts of Pakistan's capital remain under a tight security lockdown for over a week on Saturday, anticipating another round of talks between the US and Iran.

New minds, new Niti

The prime minister said that the Niti Aayog has emerged as a vital pillar in India's policy-making architecture, fostering cooperative federalism, furthering reforms and boosting 'Ease of Living.' "It serves as a dynamic platform for innovation and long-term strategic thinking across

sectors," he said. The prime minister is the chairman of the Niti Aayog. Lahiri is amongst India's most experienced and senior economists with a career spanning over four decades. Currently a BJP MLA in West Bengal, he is a former chief economic advisor to the government of India and a member of the 15th Finance Commission. He is not contesting the ongoing Assembly election in the state.

Raju is a member of the Economic Advisory Council to the prime minister. He also serves as the economic advisor to the chief minister of Uttar Pradesh. Karandikar is currently Secretary, Department of Science and Technology (DST). Before joining DST in October 2023, he served as the Director of IIT-Kanpur.

Das is the director of the Indian Institute of Science Education and Research, Bhopal. Prior to assuming this position, he was working as a professor and chair of the Special Centre for Molecular Medicine at Jawaharlal Nehru University, New Delhi. Srinivas is the director of the premier All India Institute of Medical Sciences, New Delhi. He has had an illustrious career with more than three decades of experience in various positions in the academic, administrative and research fields.

Lahiri on Saturday called on the prime minister and thanked him for his appointment. The prime minister said Lahiri's "rich experience in economics and public policy will greatly strengthen India's reform journey and the journey towards becoming a Viksit Bharat." "I am confident his efforts will further energise policy-making in our nation. My best wishes for a fruitful tenure," Modi said. The prime minister also congratulated Gobardhan Das on his appointment as a member of the government think tank.

"Your journey, filled with tireless hard work and humility, is truly inspiring for everyone. The invaluable contributions you have made in the fields of public health, science and innovation fill the entire nation with pride. My sincere best wishes for your tenure," Modi said in response to Das thanking him for the appointment.

Lahiri, in a message, said he met the prime minister to convey his deep gratitude to him and the government for reposing trust in him. He said he will serve in the key post with all sincerity, good intentions and clear policies (Niti, Niyat and Nistha) as envisioned by the prime minister.

"We will succeed in all three counts," he said.

Das also thanked the prime minister for allowing him to serve as a member of the Niti Aayog. "Today is a very important day in my life. I am the son of an ordinary farmer family from the Dalit class in a remote village of West Bengal.

"Since childhood, the fragrance of the soil, the value of hard work, and the truth of struggle have been an integral part of my life. Today's responsibility is not just a position for me; it is a glimpse of the dreams, hopes, and beliefs of countless ordinary people like me," he said in a post on X in Hindi. Das said he believed that for the development of the country, it is imperative that the quality of life in remote areas, the farming community and ordinary people is improved.

"For this purpose, I promise to work with honesty, dedication and full responsibility under the guidance of the Honourable Prime Minister,"

he said. "I seek everyone's blessings and cooperation," he added.

Lahiri takes the place of Suman K Bery, who has been the vice chairman of Niti Aayog since May 2022. Vijay Kumar Saraswat, Ramesh Chand, Vinod Kumar Paul, Arvind Virmani and Gauba were the members.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

AAP to approach...

Addressing a press conference in Delhi, AAP Rajya Sabha member and senior leader Sanjay Singh said the party will write to the Rajya Sabha Chairman to seek the disqualification of the MPs from the Upper House. "Anti-defection law clearly states that any type of split or faction cannot happen in Rajya Sabha and Lok Sabha. It does not carry any legal recognition, even if it's a two-thirds majority," Singh said. The seven MPs who have joined the BJP are completely "unconstitutional" and "illegal," he said.

Chadha said that every honest and hardworking person now feels that there is "no space left to work in the AAP" and that the party is moving on a wrong path with which no one wants to remain associated. "Because of this, leaders have been leaving the party one after another," he said.

Chadha said MPs are abandoning and leaving the AAP together because they believe the party has gone into "corrupt and compromised hands," he claimed. Mann used a culinary analogy to attack those who quit the party. In a sarcastic post on X, he wrote in Punjabi, "Ginger, garlic, cumin, fenugreek powder, red chilli, black pepper, and coriander -- these seven things together make a dish taste great, but on their own cannot become a dish."

On Friday, the AAP suffered a major setback when Chadha, Ashok Mittal, Sandeep Pathak, Harbhajan Singh, Rajendra Gupta, Vikram Sahni and Swati Malhi quit and merged the parliamentary party with the BJP. They alleged that the Arvind Kejriwal-led party had strayed from its principles, values and core morals.

Though Chadha and Malhi had fallen out of favour of the AAP, the move by the other five MPs to switch sides came as a surprise to many.

Mann has claimed that the BJP, which has repeatedly faced rejection in Punjab, has responded with hostility towards both the state and the AAP, attempting to weaken a corruption-free government through intimidation, inducements and engineering defections.

Malhiwal, who had a fallout with Kejriwal after she was allegedly assaulted by his close aide in 2024, said she quit the party as it had "strayed far" from its original principles. She alleged the party had completely changed and is now known for "lies, corruption and hooliganism."

"The real betrayal is not leaving the party, but not standing by your own principles. People are not leaving out of fear; they are leaving because of Arvind Kejriwal," she said. She claimed that more leaders would quit the party in the coming days. "No good person can work with him for long. He says one thing and does another," she said about her former boss.

AAP Lok Sabha member Malvinder Singh

Kang said there is a need for better coordination and continuous dialogue between the party leadership and its MLAs, MPs and ministers in Punjab. Meanwhile, social media platforms turned into a comedy zone with memes from "placement ho gayi jokes" to 'Hera Pheri'-style confusion and dramatic "washing machine".

Users responded with humour, sarcasm and film-style punchlines, making the political development one of the day's most talked-about online trends. Meanwhile, the BJP sharpened its attack on Kejriwal over the new central government bungalow allotted to him at Lodhi Estate here, dubbing it as "Sheesh Mahal 2" and alleging expenditure of private money to build amenities in it. The AAP has denied the allegation, calling it fake.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

IMD drops...

Coastal and eastern regions, meanwhile, are expected to experience hot and humid weather. Warm night conditions over the northern plains are further adding to discomfort and health risks. Authorities have advised people to avoid prolonged exposure to the sun during peak afternoon hours, stay well-hydrated, wear light clothing and limit strenuous outdoor activity. Extra caution has been urged for children, the elderly and those with pre-existing health conditions.

Mali attacks...

A resident of Kati, a town near Bamako that is home to Mali's main military base, also said he was woken up early in the morning by the sounds of gunfire and explosions. Gen Assimi Goita, the leader of Mali's military junta, resides in Kati. Videos on social media showed military convoys in trucks and motorcycles moving through the town's deserted streets, while residents looked on fearfully. Other videos in the northern towns of Kidal and Gao showed gunfire exchanges in the streets, with dead bodies lying on the ground. Gunmen entered Kidal, taking control of some neighbourhoods and leading to exchanges of fire with the army, a former mayor of the town told AP over the phone. He spoke on condition of anonymity out of fear for his safety.

Mohamed Elmaouloud Ramadan, a spokesperson for the Tuareg-led Azawad separatist movement, said on Facebook its forces had taken control of Kidal as well as some areas in Gao, another northeastern city. The AP could not independently verify his claim.

The separatists have been fighting for years to create the state of Azawad in northern Mali. They once drove security forces from the region, before a 2015 peace deal that has since collapsed paved the way for some ex-rebels to be integrated into the Malian military. A resident of Gao said gunfire and explosions started in the early hours of Saturday and could still be heard in the late morning. "The force of the explosions is making the doors and windows of my house shake. I'm scared out of my wits," the resident told AP

by phone. He spoke on condition of anonymity because of concerns for his safety. The resident said the gunfire came from the army camp and the airport, which are right next to each other.

The US Embassy in Bamako issued a security alert, saying "there have been reports of explosions and gunfire near Kati and the Modibo Keita International Airport in Bamako" and that "US citizens should shelter in place and avoid travel to these destinations until further information becomes available."

AGENCIES

Delhi on boil...

temperature of 42.8 degrees Celsius, 5.1 degrees above normal and a 0.9-degree rise from the day before, thus fulfilling the criteria for a heatwave. According to the India Meteorological Department, a heatwave is classified when the maximum temperature is 40 degrees Celsius or above, and it is 4.5 degrees to 6.4 degrees above normal. This was also the highest maximum recorded in Delhi in the last four years since 2022, when the maximum had reached 43.5 degrees Celsius on April 28, 2022. Safdarjung recorded a minimum temperature of 25.2 degrees Celsius, 2.5 degrees above normal and a mere 0.7-degree rise from the day before.

Other weather stations also recorded isolated heatwave conditions. Lodhi Road recorded a maximum temperature of 42.6 degrees Celsius, 5.6 degrees above the normal; Ridge recorded a minimum of 44.5 degrees, 6.1 degrees above the normal; and Ayanagar logged a minimum temperature of 43.2 degrees Celsius, 4.8 degrees above the normal.

While the IMD had initially classified Friday as the season's first isolated heat wave, the MeT department later clarified on Saturday that it had been the third consecutive day of a heatwave. IMD classifies a heatwave when at least two stations have met the required criteria.

An IMD official clarified that while Delhi had fulfilled the heatwave condition only in one station on Thursday, the two-step criteria are actually for the entire subdivision of Haryana-Chandigarh-Delhi. "On Thursday, one station, Rohtak to be specific, of Haryana and Ridge of Delhi, had satisfied heatwave criteria, thus making it the first day. Saturday was the third consecutive day of heat waves," an IMD official said.

Meanwhile, the weather department has issued a yellow alert for Sunday as well. The official added, "These conditions are likely to continue till Sunday.

Under the influence of the setting in of lower tropospheric level easterly winds, the maximum temperature might drop on Tuesday, as forecasts suggest very light rain possible from Monday. According to forecasts by the MeT department, a spell of very light rain, along with thunderstorms and gusty winds, might bring some respite from Monday to at least Wednesday. The maximum temperature is forecast to fall to 38-40 degrees Celsius by the end of next week.

The minimum temperature is likely to be around 25-27 degrees Celsius for the next couple of days.

MPPOST

AAP MPS SWITCHING SIDES

BJP washing machine back with Modi washing powder: Cong

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A day after seven AAP MPs switched sides to the BJP, the Congress on Saturday said the BJP washing machine is back along with Modi washing powder.

The Congress has been accusing the BJP of inducting leaders of various other parties facing cases and then going slow on the action against them.

Ashok Mittal, one of the seven AAP MPs who quit, had faced Enforcement Directorate raids only a few days ago.

“The BJP washing machine is back along with the Modi washing powder. Those who projected themselves as paragons of virtue, integrity, and ideology stand brutally exposed,” AICC general secretary in-charge communications Jairam Ramesh said in a post on X.

The Aam Aadmi Party suffered a jolt on Friday as seven of its Rajya Sabha members - Raghav Chadha, Mittal, Sandeep Pathak, Harbhajan Singh, Rajendra Gupta, Vikram Sahni and Swati Maliwal - quit the party and merged with the BJP. They alleged that the Arvind Kejriwal-led party had strayed from its principles, values and core morals.

Though Chadha and Maliwal had fallen out of favour of the AAP, the move by the other five MPs to switch sides came as a surprise to many.

The exits were announced at a hurriedly called press conference, after which AAP chief Kejriwal alleged that the BJP



This combo image shows Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) Rajya Sabha MPs, clockwise from top left, Raghav Chadha, Sandeep Pathak, Ashok Mittal, Swati Maliwal, Harbhajan Singh, Vikram Sahni and Rajendra Gupta PFI

Highlights

- » The Congress has been accusing the BJP of inducting leaders of various other parties facing cases and then going slow on the action against them.
- » Ashok Mittal, one of the seven AAP MPs who quit, had faced Enforcement Directorate raids only a few days ago
- » The BJP, however, refuted the charge and said the Aam Aadmi Party MPs were dissatisfied with their leadership and hence wanted to join the BJP

had betrayed the people of Punjab while state Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann termed the seven MPs “gaddar” (traitors).

Meanwhile, the DMK on Saturday accused the BJP of resorting to “fraudulent and anti-democratic tactics” and said the saffron party was the “biggest purchaser of AAP MPs.”

The BJP, however, refuted the charge and said the Aam Aadmi Party MPs were dissatisfied with their leadership and hence wanted to join the BJP.

Reacting to the development, DMK spokesperson TKS

Elangovan, said, “The BJP is the biggest purchaser of MPs and MLAs. They will resort to any fraudulent activity. They have no faith in democracy. They want to somehow capture power. They will do all wrongs, all anti-democratic, anti-constitutional activities to come to power. That is the BJP. The worst political party in India is the BJP.”

Meanwhile, welcoming AAP MPs into the BJP, the party’s Tamil Nadu chief spokesperson Narayanan Tirupathy said the Rajya Sabha members were dissatisfied with their party.

Bengal polls: ‘BJP will win 110 seats in phase 1’

Amit Shah promises swift implemmentation of CAA in Bengal

MPOST BUREAU

KOLKATA: Union Home minister Amit Shah on Friday asserted that the BJP virtually sealed its victory in phase 1 of the West Bengal Assembly polls itself, claiming the party would win 110 seats in the first leg of polling and promising swift implementation of the CAA, a crackdown on infiltration, and a “fear-free” Bengal for women after coming to power.

Addressing back-to-back rallies in Jamalpur of Purba Bardhaman district and Shyampur in Howrah, Shah sharpened the BJP’s campaign around three of its core Bengal planks—the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA) for the Matua community, women’s safety, and alleged infiltration



Union Home minister Amit Shah being felicitated during a public meeting, in Purba Bardhaman PFI

from Bangladesh—while projecting the election as a battle to end Mamata Banerjee’s rule.

“Voting for the first phase is over. In the very first phase itself, the BJP will win 110 seats, and Didi (Mamata Banerjee) will be thrown out of power.

‘Mamata helping rich, not poor in Bengal, PM doing same across country’

KOLKATA: Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Saturday sought to put Prime Minister Narendra Modi and West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee in the same bracket, accusing both of helping the rich instead of the poor, while hankering for power.

Addressing an election rally at Serampore in Hooghly district, Gandhi said that Modi “claims to be a ‘deshbhakt’ (patriot), but is selling off the country.”

“While CM Mamata Banerjee is helping the rich, and not the poor in West Bengal, Modi is doing the same across the country... Both have nothing to do with creating job opportunities. They want power but don’t work for people,” he said.

“Wherever the PM goes, he spreads hatred and fear among people,” the leader of the Opposition in Lok Sabha alleged.



Congress leader Rahul Gandhi during a rally at Sahid Minar maidan on Saturday PIC/ GAUTAM BOSE

He claimed that the country is witnessing a fight between two ideologies.

“It is the Congress’ unity and brotherhood against the BJP and RSS’ hatred and violence,” he added. He accused the PM of harming small industries in the country through demonetisation and implementing GST in

Instead of TMC, BJP will form the government here,” he said.

Polling was held in 152 of the 294 Assembly constituencies on April 23 and recorded a turnout of nearly 93 per cent. The second phase of polling for the remaining 142 seats will be held on April 29. Results will be announced on May 4.

With the politically influential Matua community’s vote central to BJP’s electoral calculations in several border districts, Shah accused Banerjee of deliberately blocking the implementation of the CAA and keeping those refugee families in uncertainty for vote-bank politics.

“Didi does not allow the implementation of the CAA. You form the government of

the lotus, and after May 5, the BJP government will ensure that every brother and sister of the Matua community receives citizenship,” he said.

The former BJP president said members of the Matua community, many of whom migrated from Bangladesh and remain emotionally tied to the citizenship debate, would no longer have to “live in fear” under a BJP government.

“Infiltrators in Bengal are eating away at our youths’ jobs and the poor’s rations. Didi and her nephew (TMC MP Abhishek Banerjee) are nurturing infiltrators for the sake of their vote bank. After May 5, the BJP government will handpick and drive out every single infiltrator from Bengal,” Shah said.

UP: PM Modi to inaugurate Ganga Expressway on April 29

LUCKNOW: The Ganga Expressway project, set to bring a major transformation in Uttar Pradesh’s infrastructure landscape, has now reached its final stage, and Prime Minister Narendra Modi is scheduled to inaugurate it on April 29.

With an estimated cost of around Rs 37,000 crore, the mega project was divided into four major packages (groups) to ensure rapid progress.

This “multi-package” model proved to be the project’s biggest strength, playing a crucial role in delivering such a massive project within the stipulated timeline, the UP govt said in a statement on Saturday. MPOST

EC says no re-poll in any TN polling station

OUR CORRESPONDENT

CHENNAI: The Election Commission on Saturday said no re-poll was recommended in any polling station in the Tamil Assembly election held on April 23.

The election was conducted in a total of 75,064 polling stations across the state, with as many as 4,023 candidates contesting.

In a statement, the ECI said the entire process was video-graphed, and after scrutiny, forms 17A and related materials were re-sealed with the election authorities’ seal.

The EVMs and VVPATs have been stored securely in the strong rooms, which have been sealed after the polling concluded on April 23 in the presence of general observers and candidates or their representatives. MPOST

The election was conducted in a total of 75,064 polling stations across the state, with as many as 4,023 candidates contesting

The ECI further said elaborate arrangements have been made for the security of the EVM strong rooms, including a double-lock system, deployment of two-tier security round the clock and CCTV coverage of the doors/corridors of the strong rooms.

The revenue officials have been directed to visit the strong rooms and check the arrangements twice a day, while EC officials will visit the strong rooms once in three days

Amritsar traders meet Haryana CM to boost business expansion

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: A delegation of traders from Majitha Mandi, Amritsar, Punjab, met Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Saturday at his residence, Sant Kabir Kutir, Chandigarh.

The meeting focused on expanding their business operations and exploring investment opportunities in Haryana.

During the discussion, the traders proposed expanding their wholesale dry fruit business to Sonipat.

The Chief Minister responded positively and approved the proposal. He reiterated that the Haryana government is committed to promoting trade and industry and is ensuring all necessary support and facilities for investors.

Welcoming the traders from Amritsar to Haryana, Saini said the state is working on the prin-



Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini addressing the press conference in Chandigarh, Saturday MPOST

ciple of ‘Ease of Doing Business’, ensuring transparent, simple, and efficient processes. Haryana is emerging as a major industrial and logistics hub in the country, offering a conducive environment for investment, he added.

He further said that expansions of major business centres like Khari Baoli and Bhagirath Palace in Delhi have already been approved in the Rai (Sonipat) area, as part of efforts

to develop it into a large commercial hub.

The Chief Minister assured that the state government will fully support and protect investors, enabling them to grow their businesses successfully.

Meanwhile, Haryana Chief Minister announced that starting from next week, farmers across the state will receive QR code-based J-Forms through WhatsApp. It will make it easier for farmers to access loans and other services without any inconvenience.

He said that from the next procurement season, a dedicated ‘Kisan App’ will be launched. The app will provide farmers with J-Forms, payment status, crop sowing and verification details, gate pass scheduling, land verification status, and other key information through the e-Kharid system, ensuring a faster and more efficient procurement process.

Ghazipur teen death: SP, Congress demand justice

Akhilesh slams pressure on victim’s family

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GHAZIPUR: As Prime Minister Narendra Modi is scheduled to visit Uttar Pradesh for the inauguration of an expressway on April 29, Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav is set to visit the family of a Dalit girl whose death has triggered a political storm in the state.

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Saturday claimed that the victim, belonging to the Vishwakarma community, was raped and brutally killed and that her family was threatened to prevent the filing of an FIR.

Congress general secretary Priyanka Gandhi Vadra said that atrocities against women were at their peak in Uttar Pradesh.

SP president Akhilesh

Yadav told reporters at the party headquarters that BJP leaders met the girl’s father.

“The BJP seeks to extract political mileage from every situation. However, I am heartened to see that society at large is becoming increasingly aware and the ‘PDA’ (pichhda or backward classes, Dalit, alp-sankhyak or minority) is even more vigilant,” he said.

Later, in a post on X, Yadav alleged a new “disturbing” trend under the BJP government: they commit or orchestrate atrocities and later exert pressure on the victims to recant their statements.

“Exploiting the helplessness of a poor person constitutes the most inhumane form of injustice. The BJP’s governance and administrative machinery are currently passing through their most abysmal phase,” he said.

CM Mann orders deadline-bound flood protection works, directs all DCs

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: With Punjab heading towards the monsoon season, Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Saturday ordered Deputy Commissioners to complete all flood protection works within deadline, warning officials of personal accountability for lapses.

Chairing a high-level review meeting, he directed urgent desilting of drains and vulnerable points, fast-tracked anti-pollution measures, and pushed pending infrastructure projects as the state moves to prevent floods and strengthen water management before the rains arrive.

CM Mann, accompanied by Rajya Sabha MP Sant Balbir Singh Seechewal, battled for fool proof planning and execution of the master plan for carrying out flood protection works effec-



tively across the state.

He said, “The plan of drains and rivers should be prepared in sync with the engineers of the irrigation department to ensure their regular de-silting, cleaning, and strengthening of flood protection works.”

He emphasised, “This will be instrumental in saving people from the wrath of floods during the monsoon season, and every officer will be personally accountable for this work. The desilting of Gidderpindi Railway Bridge and other places prone to floods should

be done at the earliest to avert any flood-like situation.”

On the cleaning of Buddha Nullah, the Punjab CM added, “The water of the sacred Buddha Nullah has been cleaned up to the starting point of Ludhiana city, and cleaning work beyond this point is ongoing. Cow dung waste from dairies into Buddha Nullah should be checked with a heavy hand. The Municipal Corporation must ensure proper lifting of cow dung from the dairies, and dairy owners should cooperate.”

TN: Two workers killed in explosion at firecracker unit

OUR CORRESPONDENT

THENI: Two workers were killed in a powerful explosion at a firecracker manufacturing unit near Cumbum in this district on Saturday, police said.

The mishap occurred at a factory located on Kattupallivasal road.

The unit, owned by one Muthulakshmi, had reportedly been closed for the past four days due to election holidays and had only reopened for work on Saturday morning.

According to police sources, the blast took place when two workers, identified as Surya (22) and Dinesh alias Deena (23), opened the room where raw materials and chemicals were stored.

The duo was killed on the spot as the impact of the explosion caused their bodies to be ripped apart.

Two other workers, Ayyapan and Nagarjun, who were present at the facility, managed to escape unhurt as they fled the premises immediately after hearing the loud blast.

Madhya Pradesh tops PM SVANidhi rollout; Indore leads national urban rankings

The state disburses Rs 2,632 crore to 9.92 lakh vendors, leads in digital push and repayment under revamped scheme

SATYAPRAKASH SHARMA

BHOPAL: Madhya Pradesh has emerged as the top-performing state in the country in the implementation of the Pradhan Mantri Street Vendor’s AtmaNirbhar Nidhi (PM SVANidhi) scheme, extending critical financial support to over 9.92 lakh street vendors and reinforcing its lead in inclusive urban livelihood initiatives.

According to the Union Housing and Urban Affairs Ministry’s SVANidhi portal, the state ranks first nationally with 68.87 per cent target achievement, disbursing 15.69 lakh loans to 9.92 lakh beneficiaries, followed by Andhra Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Telangana and Punjab.

Sanket Bhondave, Commissioner of the Urban Administration and Development Department, said Madhya Pradesh has disbursed Rs



2,632 crore through 15.69 lakh loans to 9.92 lakh beneficiaries. The scheme, which provides affordable working capital to street vendors, has been extended till March 31, 2030, with revised loan slabs of Rs 15,000, Rs 25,000 and Rs

50,000.

Bhondave said the state has accelerated digital integration, issuing UPI-linked credit cards with a Rs 30,000 limit, with over 7 lakh vendors earning more than Rs 47 crore in cashback through digital transactions.

Key Points

- » Women beneficiaries: 40% (3.71 lakh)
- » Leads in Rs 50,000 loans: 1.38 lakh cases
- » Strong repayment: 60% in 2nd phase; 41% in 3rd
- » Digital push: 7 lakh+ vendors, Rs 47 crore cashback

The scheme’s social impact is reflected in strong gender outreach in the state, with women comprising nearly 40 per cent (3.71 lakh) of beneficiaries. The state also leads in disbursement of Rs 50,000 third-phase loans, with 1.38 lakh cases sanctioned, the Commissioner said.

Strong repayment trends underscore the scheme’s success, with nearly 60 per cent (5.43 lakh) of

vendors moving to the second loan cycle and 41 per cent (1.81 lakh) qualifying for the third phase.

At the urban local body level, Indore Municipal Corporation has emerged as the top performer nationally, disbursing 33,332 loans and surpassing major metros including Mumbai, Delhi, Bengaluru, Chennai, Kolkata and Hyderabad.

Other MP cities also ranked prominently, with Bhopal and Jabalpur securing second and third positions in the 10–40 lakh category, Ujjain fifth in the 1–10 lakh segment, and Sarni topping the under-1 lakh category, followed by Balaghat, Tikamgarh and Harda in the top ten.

Beyond credit, the state is integrating social security through a socio-economic survey, profiling 7.67 lakh vendors—including 2.91 lakh women—to link them with eight central welfare schemes.

Nation Briefs

MAHA: WOMAN KILLED IN TREE COLLAPSE INCIDENT IN BEED DISTRICT

BEED: A 55-year-old woman died after a neem tree collapsed in an agricultural field at Mogara in Majalgaon tehsil of the district, police said. The incident took place at around 4 pm on Friday as strong winds lashed the area. The deceased was identified as Sumanbai Haribhau Ghanghav, a goat herder. A branch of the tree pierced Ghangav’s abdomen, causing her serious injuries, said a police official. She was shifted to a hospital in Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar but doctors declared her dead on arrival. Ghangav was the primary breadwinner for her family, local sources said. Mogara residents and members of the local community have requested the government to provide immediate financial assistance to the Ghanghav family.

UP: MAN DIES BY SUICIDE, ALLEGES HARASSMENT BY WOMAN IN MUZAFFARNAGAR

MUZAFFARNAGAR: A 27-year-old man died by suicide in Garhi Deshraj village here on Saturday after a woman and her mother allegedly harassed and blackmailed him by threatening to circulate his private photographs, police said. Circle Officer (Phugana) Yatendra Singh Nagar told reporters that Ayush’s body was found hanging from the ceiling inside his house, located in Titavi Police Station area of Muzaffarnagar district of Uttar Pradesh. Police recovered a suicide note in which the deceased accused a woman and her mother of harassing him and threatening to circulate his private photographs.

PBKS pull off king-size chase

Punjab Kings script record chase against DC to stay unbeaten

BENGALURU: Punjab Kings rewrote the T20 record books with a breathtaking batting blitz, pulling off the highest-ever successful chase in the format's history by overhauling a daunting 265-run target to outgun Delhi Capitals by six wickets in an IPL run-fest here on Saturday.

KL Rahul blended grace with power to script a stroke-filled 152, the third-highest individual IPL score, while Nitish Rana (91) batted with authority as the duo powered hosts Delhi Capitals to a mammoth 264 for 2 after opting to bat first.

Chasing the target, Punjab's dynamic opening pair of Prabhshimran Singh (76) and Priyansh Arya (73) came out all guns blazing, adding 126 runs in just 42 balls to lay a formidable foundation for the chase and set the tone for their sixth win of the season.

Skipper Shreyas Iyer, who was dropped by Karun Nair twice in the span of three balls, then scored an unbeaten 71 off 36 deliveries to take PBKS over the line with as many as seven balls to spare.

Incidentally, the previous highest successful run chase in T20 as well as IPL history also belongs to PBKS when they chased down 262 against the



PBKS' captain Shreyas Iyer, dropped multiple times, scored an unbeaten 71 off 36 balls

PTI

Kolkata Knight Riders in 2024. They remain unbeaten this season and on top of the points table with 11 points from six games.

In a match where 49 boundaries and 33 sixes were hit, with only six wickets falling, the bowlers were arguably the biggest losers.

The visitors showed remarkable composure and intent, building on their previous outing where they had scored the previous highest total of the season.

116

Runs scored by PBKS in the first six overs - the second-highest powerplay score ever in the IPL

Local lad Priyansh and

Prabhshimran consistently sent the ball to and over the fence. The latter hit six fours against Mukesh Kumar in the sixth over.

There were anxious moments during the chase when Delhi Capitals pacer Lungi Ngidi was hit the back of the head on the ground while attempting a catch off Arya's bat. The South African had to be stretchered off the field after a delay of over 15 minutes, momentarily halting proceedings.

AGENCIES

Ngidi stable, to be discharged

NEW DELHI: Delhi Capitals pacer Lungi Ngidi is "stable" and will be "discharged shortly" from a local hospital where he underwent medical examination after he hurt himself during his side's IPL match against Punjab Kings here on Saturday.

The South African was taken off the ground in an ambulance after he nastily banged his head into the ground while attempting a catch. He was rushed to BLK-Max Super Speciality Hospital here for medical examination.

The IPL said that the 30-year-old right-arm pacer complained of headache and neck pain, but he is currently "stable". He was shifted to the hospital in an ambulance as he complained of a headache and neck pain," IPL said on X.

"Ngidi is stable and is due to be discharged shortly from the hospital."

AGENCIES

TITANS EYE RETURN TO WINNING

Rejuvenated CSK look to step it up as GT seek course correction

CHENNAI: Riding a resurgent run, Chennai Super Kings will look to consolidate their position in the top half, while Gujarat Titans aim to arrest a slide when the two sides face off in a crucial mid-season IPL clash here on Sunday.

After a sluggish start, CSK have turned things around, winning three of their last four matches, including a commanding 103-run victory over Mumbai Indians that was powered by Sanju Samson's second century of the season.

Led by Ruturaj Gaikwad, CSK are placed just outside the top four with six points and will be keen to avoid further slip-ups as they chase a play-off berth.

At the moment, things are looking up for CSK. Samson's brilliance with the bat, complemented by a clinical bowling effort led by Akeal Hosein, scripted their emphatic win over Mumbai.

Notably, they achieved it without talisman MS Dhoni (calf injury) and local talent Ayush Mhatre (hamstring), who has contributed 201 runs this season.

However, a few concerns remain. While the top order has delivered consistently, the middle order has struggled to show intent and build part-



MS Dhoni bats at nets on the eve of the match

PTI

KKR, LSG fight to stay alive

LUCKNOW: The adage that a captain is only as good as his team holds a grim truth for Rishabh Pant and Ajinkya Rahane. As Lucknow Super Giants and Kolkata Knight Riders prepare to meet this Sunday in the IPL, both find their leadership under fire, mirroring the fading fortunes of their respective franchises. KKR's bold call to persist with Rahane at the helm after a woe-laden IPL 2025 campaign was debated even before the tournament began. The concerns have only deepened as results failed to follow.

It took them seven matches to register their first win -- a narrow escape powered by individual brilliance from Rinku Singh rather than a collective resurgence.

AGENCIES

nerships. Against Sunrisers Hyderabad, CSK should have comfortably chased down 130 from 90 balls with eight wickets in hand, but a middle-order collapse derailed the effort.

Gaikwad himself is enduring a lean run, much like Riyan Parag for Rajasthan Royals, while the likes of Sarfaraz Khan, Shivam Dube and Dewald Brevis have failed to convert starts into substantial scores.

AGENCIES

HEAPS PRAISE ON KOHLI

Padikkal finds T20 edge via K'taka stint



Devdutt Padikkal slammed a fifty against Gujarat Titans

PTI

BENGALURU: Devdutt Padikkal credited his stint as captain of Karnataka cricket team and some tactical tweaks for sharpening his game awareness and aiding his evolution into a more complete T20 batter.

Padikkal was speaking after Royal Challengers Bengaluru's win over Gujarat Titans in the Indian Premier League here on Friday, in which he played a key role alongside Virat Kohli and their bowling unit.

Padikkal said leadership responsibilities at the domestic level have given him a deeper understanding of match situations and opposition tactics.

"Definitely, I think being a captain has given me a different perspective of the game. It makes you think a lot more about how a bowler thinks, how captains are thinking on the field, what they might look to do. That has helped me refine parts of my game and respond better to situations," he said at the post-match press conference.

"It gives me a little bit more of an understanding as to the situation that I'm in and how I need to respond. So yeah, I guess being the captain of Karnataka has definitely contributed in a positive way."

I think the biggest thing for me is his (Kohli's) energy and intensity that he brings to every single game, every single net session

Devdutt Padikkal on Kohli

The left-hander, who has shown marked improvement in his white-ball approach, added that his transformation is part of a natural progression.

"I think it's time we forget the previous version. This is who I am now. You identify areas to improve and keep working on them," he said.

Padikkal heaped praise on the great Kohli for the kind of intensity with which he plays the game despite achieving almost everything cricket could offer. His big partnership with Kohli sealed the issue in RCB's favour as they completed a chase of 206 with seven balls to spare. He said Kohli's intensity and passion rubs on to others in the dressing room.

‘One more run’ wins it for Punjab; Rahul evolves with Nayar’s T20 plan

NEW DELHI: Leading Indians opening batter KL Rahul may have ended up on the losing side despite scoring the third highest IPL score of 152 but his innings inspired Punjab Kings to pull off the highest ever successful run chase of 265 in the T20 format, revealed the winning skipper Shreyas Iyer.

After the match, Iyer said the side kept a simple mindset: "score one more than the opposition".

"Kudos to KL (Rahul). The way he played was fabulous and pleasing to the eye. In my mind, I was just saying that whatever they get from here on, I think we just have to score one more run and ensure we become victorious," said Iyer at the post-match presentation.

"That was the mindset, nothing more, honestly speaking, because whatever balls the bowlers were bowling at that particular time, I think he was improvising and he was playing beautiful shots (on KL). So it didn't look like he was trying really hard. I just said to myself that if they can, we can too."

"We discussed that in the previous games, we chased around 220-225 with two overs left. So the mindset was very much similar. Get as many runs as possible in the power-

AGENCIES



Delhi Capitals' KL Rahul celebrates 150 runs

PTI

‘Kudos to KL (Rahul). The way he played was fabulous’

play and they just went bonkers from ball one and steadied the ship for us. We just wanted to capitalise on the start. Right now, we just want to have as much fun as possible and relax because we had three days of hard work, practicing in the heat and playing in the heat. So, you know, relax a bit and then the day after, we'll rejuvenate and probably go back to the drawing board..."

Rahul credits Nayar

At the innings break, it looked like to be a one-sided

affair following Rahul's splendid 152 not out. He was adjudged player-of-the-match and he revealed getting extensive inputs from Abhishek Nayar to upgrade his T20 approach.

"I was very pleased, very happy at the end of the first 20 overs. It's something that I've been working on for a very long time behind the scenes. Just said this last year as well. I spent a lot of time with Abhishek Nayar," said Rahul.

He further stressed the need to reassess his game in line with evolving trends.

"Just to step back a little bit and see where T20 games have gone and what the demand of T20 cricket is in today's day and age."

AGENCIES

Bayern recover from 3 goals down to beat Mainz

BERLIN: Bundesliga champions Bayern Munich survived a scare, fighting back from three goals down to beat Mainz 4-3 on Saturday for a morale-booster before facing Paris Saint-Germain.

Bayern, which goes to Paris on Tuesday for the first leg of their Champions League semifinal, arrived in Mainz in good cheer after clinching the title last weekend and reaching the German Cup final with a win over Bayer Leverkusen on Wednesday.

But Mainz romped to a deserved 3-0 half-time lead against a heavily-rotated Bayern team,

with Harry Kane, Jamal Musiala and Michael Olise among those on the bench.

Mainz might even have scored more than the goals that came from from Dominik Kohr, Paul Nebel and Sheraldo Becker.

Bayern coach Vincent Kompany sent on Kane and Olise for Luis Diaz and Aleksandar Pavlovic at the break – all four are likely to start against PSG.

Nicolas Jackson pulled one back in the 53rd and Olise let fly with a brilliant strike inside the far post in the 73rd before Musiala equalized in the 81st.

AGENCIES

Portugal's Fernandes hopes to win WC to crown CR7's career



MANCHESTER: Portugal midfielder Bruno Fernandes expressed hope that he and his teammates can help crown Cristiano Ronaldo's international career by winning the 2026 World Cup.

The 41-year-old Ronaldo is set to appear in a record sixth World Cup in June, a tournament expected to be the final major chapter of the forward's career.

"Wrapping up all this last World Cup with Cristiano (Ronaldo) winning it would be something amazing," Fernandes told Wayne Rooney in a BBC report published on Friday. "I really hope we can make it happen, not just for Portugal, but for everything Cris-

tiano gave to football and the world," the Portuguese midfielder and Manchester United captain said.

Ronaldo, considered one of the greatest players ever to haven't won a World Cup, is the record scorer in international football with 143 goals.

The five-time Ballon d'Or winner was part of Portugal's Euro 2016-winning team and has lifted the Nations League twice.

Portugal's opening Group K game is on June 17 against the Democratic Republic of Congo, followed by Uzbekistan on June 23, with both games in Houston. They play Colombia on June 27 in Miami in their final group game.

Vanshika and Chirag win 10m air pistol mixed team gold

CAIRO: Vanshika Chaudhary and Chirag Sharma won the 10m air pistol mixed team event at the ISSF Junior World Cup here on Saturday, taking India's gold tally to five.

With one more day of competitions left, India continued to lead the medal table with five gold, five silver and four bronze.

The duo shot 484.3 to shrug off the challenge of Aliaksandra Piatrova and Mikita Dauhach (467.6) representing the Individual Neutral Athletes (AIN). The second Indian pair of Mohini Singh and Himanshu Rana tallied 407.4 to clinch bronze in the four-team final.

Vanshika and Chirag had earlier shot a combined 582 on Saturday morning at the Olympic International City Shooting range to top the 14-team qualifiers while Mohini and Himanshu finished third as well with a 568. It was a second gold in the tournament for Vanshika having earlier won the individual women's 10m air pistol title. It was also a second medal for Chirag, who had earlier won bronze in the junior men's air pistol.

The Trap men's and women's competitions also concluded on the day where India had one finalist each.

AGENCIES

Barcelona close in on La Liga title without the injured Yamal

BARCELONA: Barcelona closed in on a second consecutive La Liga title after Fermin López and Marcus Rashford scored to help earn its first win at Getafe in six seasons on Saturday.

Fermin dedicated his 45th-minute opener to the injured Lamine Yamal, Barcelona's leading scorer and assist maker who will miss the rest of the season with a muscle injury but hopes to be fit for the World Cup with Spain.

After scoring, Fermin crossed his arms and held up his fingers to make the "304" sign that Yamal uses to celebrate his goals in reference to the final three numbers of the post code for his hometown just north of Barcelona.

Rashford went on as a substitute and sealed the 2-0 victory in the 74th with a



Marcus Rashford scores his side's second goal

AP

solo effort.

Barcelona increased the gap over second-placed Real Madrid to a commanding 11 points with just five rounds to go, including a clasico between them at Camp Nou on May 10.

"We know that we have a big lead but there are still games left. It sounds like a cliché but it

Fermin dedicated his 45th-minute opener to the injured Lamine Yamal

is true," Fermin said. "We have to keep this going before we can become champions."

Getafe's physical and no-frills defense stymied Barcelona for half a decade in their meetings at Coliseum Stadium. Barcelona had scored only once in its previous five trips to southern Madrid, a run of four straight draws and a loss in 2020. Barcelona's previous

win here was in 2019.

Betis dash Real's hopes

SEVILLE: Real Madrid's already slim hopes of winning La Liga were dealt another blow when Real Betis scored a stoppage-time equalizer in a pulsating 1-1 result.

Madrid was left trailing league leader Barcelona by eight points with only five games to play. Barcelona has a game in hand at Getafe on Saturday. The match started well for visiting Madrid as Vinicius Junior scored for the second time in four days. Betis goalkeeper Alvaro Valles could only parry Federico Valverde's long range shot and the Brazilian striker followed up to slot in the rebound. Betis, though, was not overawed and Andriy Lunin, in goal for the injured Thibaut Courtois, made at least two world-class saves.

AGENCIES

HUNGRY AS EVER
Kohli's mindset sets him apart, says Dahiya



Virat Kohli starred for RCB in their win over GT

PTI

BENGALURU: Gujarat Titans assistant coach Vijay Dahiya heaped rich praise on Virat Kohli, saying the former India captain's relentless drive and hunger to improve continue to set him apart.

Kohli won the Man of the Match award for his match-defining 44-ball 81 in RCB's five-wicket win against GT in the Indian Premier League here on Friday.

Dahiya revealed that Kohli was disappointed despite his strong innings, reflecting the batter's high standards.

"After the game, he was saying he could have converted it into a hundred. That tells you about his mindset," Dahiya said at the post-match press conference.

Highlighting what makes Kohli special, Dahiya pointed to his energy, awareness and ability to control the game.

"When you are commanding the situation, you make bowlers bowl where you want. He made the wicket look easy, but it wasn't," Dahiya noted, adding that the knock came against "world-class bowlers".

"I think it's amazing. If you look at his energy... his awareness, his energy and his willingness.

"That willingness to do well... his mindset sets him apart from a lot of other people."

"He is still one of the best runners and keeps pushing youngsters for extra runs. That willingness to do well -- that 'zid' (relentless drive) -- is what stands out," Dahiya said.

The GT assistant coach stressed that Kohli's motivation is internal rather than driven by external expectations.

ISL: Bengaluru, Mumbai draw

BENGALURU: Hosts Bengaluru FC were held to a goal-less draw by Mumbai City FC in a tightly-contested ISL game with both sides squandering chances in an end-to-end contest here. The opening exchanges were played with high intensity, with Mumbai City FC coming closest to breaking the deadlock in the first 20 minutes.

“After the game, he was saying he could have converted it into a hundred. That tells you about his mindset

— Vijay Dahiya, Gujarat Titans assistant coach

“He is not playing to prove a point to anyone. It's about the man in the mirror -- trying to be better than yesterday,” he explained.

On the match, Dahiya admitted GT may have fallen short by some more runs with the bat, having been restricted to 205 after looking good for more than 220 at one stage.

“We probably could have had a few more runs on the board,” he said, while maintaining that the team's aggressive template remains unchanged.

“The approach has been driven by fearless cricket, especially from youngsters,” he added.

Dahiya also dismissed suggestions that experienced batters need to take cues from the younger generation.

“It's not about young or experienced. Everyone has a role. Experienced players know how to adapt, and they are self-inspired,” he said.

“So we didn't have an off-spinner, and for a left-arm bowler to face a left-arm batter, it makes sense. We did what we could do, and he batted really well.”

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
Tender Notice No.: TMC/CPOH/PRY/J26-27-01 Date: 23.04.2026
E-Tender Notice
Dy. CE / CPOH/ Workshop / North Central Railway / Prayagraj for and on behalf of the President of India, invites "Open" E-Tender on prescribed form for the following work upto 15:00 hrs on 14.05.2026. The details of the Tender are as under:-
SN.1. Tender No.: TMC-CPOH-PRY-J01-26-27
Name of work: Disassembly, Repair and assembly of Lifting Unit for CSM/ WST/UNI/UNI 4S/MPT/MFI/09-3X Tamping Express machine & vibration unit of DGS & DTE machine as per schedule of work at CPOH Workshop, Prayagraj
Approx Cost: ₹ 17830041.31 Earnest Money: ₹ 356600.00
Cost of Tender Form: Nil Complete period: 24 Month
Date of Opening tender: 14.05.2026, Similar work for Eligibility Criteria: Any job work related to Tamping/Lifting unit of Track Machines.
Note : (1) The complete information along with tender document of above E-Tenders are available on Website www.ireps.gov.in up to 15:00 hrs. on the due date of tender opening. (2) Bids other than in the form of E-Bids shall not be accepted against above tenders. For this purpose, vendors are required to get themselves registered with IREPS website along with Digital Signature Certificate issued by CCA under IT Act-2000. (3) Rates entered into Financial Rate page and duly signed digitally shall be considered. Rates and any other financial entity in any other form / letter head, if attached by vendors shall be straightaway ignored and shall not be considered. (4) The supplier / contractor of goods and / or services would be subject to GST Act and Rules as applicable from time to time. (5) Document being attached should be signed by the tenderer on its body. (6) This tender notice has also been uploaded on www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in. (7) Payment of Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) in respect of e-tendering shall be accepted through net banking or payment gateway only or as per provision stipulated in applicable GCC. (8) In case of any difficulty, helpdesk available on the website of IREPS may be approached. (9) Tender online can be submitted upto 15:00 hrs on 14.05.2026. 900/26 FA
North central railways @ CPRONCR www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
E-Tender Notice No.: Sr.DEE/RS/ELS/CNB/2026-27/ET-04 Date- 24.04.2026
E-Tender Notice
Senior Divisional Electrical Engineer/RS/N.C. Rly. /Kanpur, for and on behalf of the President of India, invite the following open E-Tender for the following work up to Tender Opening Date & Time. The details of the tenders are as under: -
Tender No.: ELS-CNB-2026-27-ET-04
Name of work: Comprehensive Repair/Renewal Propulsion System in Three Phase Electric Locomotive of ELS/CNB. Qty-66 Loco Sets.
Approximate Value: ₹ 19,08,05,994.72 (Rs. Nineteen Crore Eight Lakh Five Thousand Nine Hundred Ninety Four and Seventy Two paise only). Bid Security: ₹ 38,16,100.00 (Rs. Thirty Eight Lakh Sixteen Thousand One Hundred Only). Completion period of work: 36 Months. Tender Document Cost: Nil. Tender Opening Date & Time: 18.05.2026, 15.30 hrs.
Note: - 1. The complete information along with tender document of above e-Tenders is available on website www.ireps.gov.in up to due date & time of tender opening. 2. Bids, other than in the form of E-Bids, shall not be accepted against above Tenders. For this purpose, vendors are required to get themselves registered with IREPS website along with Digital Signature Certificates issued by CCA under IT Act-2000. 3. Offer rates quoted in the form of e-tender schedule & duly signed digitally shall be final. No other documents related to offer rates shall be entertained. Tenderers are advised not to attach any document related to offer rates (except undertaking(s) asked). These documents shall be treated as NULL and void and shall not be considered for evaluation of offer. 4. Documents being attached should be signed by the tenderer on its body. 5. This tender notice has also been uploaded on www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in. 6. In case of any difficulty helpdesk available on the website of IREPS may be approached 908/26 FA
North central railways @ CPRONCR www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
E-TENDERING TENDER NOTICE Date: 22.04.2026
For & on behalf of President of India, Sr. Divisional Mechanical Engineer (Coaching), North Central Railway, Prayagraj invites OPEN E-Tenders in prescribed forms, from reputed contractors with adequate experience and financial capability for the under mentioned work up to 15:00 Hrs of Date of closing of tender.
SN E-Tender no. Tender Value Bid Security
1 NCR-M-PRY-J-VB-PPL-01-26 ₹ 16,37,065.21 ₹ 32800
Name of Work: Supply, installation and Commissioning of Pneumatic Pipeline along washing line.
Tender system: Single packet system | Cost of E-tender Form: NIL
Period of Work: 06 months | Minimum Eligibility Criteria: NOT APPLICABLE
2 NCR-M-PRY-J-SRH-02-26 ₹ 98,51,698.60 ₹ 197000
Name of Work: Provision of Rolling in/out examination huts with high-speed cameras and rolling lights having compact design over PRYJ division.
Tender system: Single packet system | Cost of E-tender Form: NIL
Period of Work: 72 months | Minimum Eligibility Criteria: APPLICABLE
Date of publishing on IREPS website: For S.N. 1 & 2, 22.04.2026
Date of closing of tender: For S.N. 1 & 2, 14.05.2026
Notes: 1. The complete information along with tender booklet of above E-Tender will be available since Date of publishing on IREPS website. 2. The online E-Tender can be submitted online only on the IREPS website up to 15:00 hrs on the due date of Tender closing. 3. Bids other than in the form of E-Bids shall not be accepted against above tenders. 4. Minimum Eligibility Criteria: NOT APPLICABLE IN THIS TENDER. 5. In case of any difficulty helpdesk available on the website of IREPS may be approached. 901/26 (ADM)
North central railways www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in @ CPRONCR

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 Cr. P.C
Whereas complaint has been made before me that the Accused No.1 Shahzadi, W/o.: Sh. Md. Akil, R/o. H.No.A-527, Amarपुरi, Nabl Karim, Delhi, Accused No.2 Saguhi Parveen @ Sawauia, S/o.: Sh. Md. Akil, R/o. H.No.A-527, Amarपुरi, Nabl Karim, Delhi, Accused No.3 Tarannum Parveen, S/o.: Sh. Md. Akil, R/o. H.No.A-527, Amarपुरi, Nabl Karim, Delhi and Accused No.4 Tapassum Parveen, S/o.: Sh. Md. Akil, R/o. H.No. A-555, Amarपुरi, Nabl Karim, Delhi have committed (or are suspected to have committed) the offence in a Case FIR No.253/2019 U/s 323/341 IPC registered at P.S. Nabl Karim, Central District, New Delhi and it has been returned on a warrant of arrest thereupon issued stating that the said Accused Shahzadi, Saguhi Parveen @ Sawauia, Tarannum Parveen and Tapassum Parveen could not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that accused Shahzadi, Saguhi Parveen @ Sawauia, Tarannum Parveen and Tapassum Parveen are absconded (or are concealing themselves to avoid the service of the said warrant).
Proclamation is hereby made that the said Shahzadi, Saguhi Parveen @ Sawauia, Tarannum Parveen and Tapassum Parveen accused of FIR No.253/2019 U/s 323/341 IPC, P.S. Nabl Karim, Central District, New Delhi are required to appear before the court to answer the said complaint on or before 30.05.2026.
By Order, Dr. Raj Kumar Singh
Judicial Magistrate First Class-05 (Central), Room No.241, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED
(See Section 82 Cr. PC)
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person namely Asif S/o Abid R/o H.No. B-309, Gali No.2, Indira Vihar, Mustafabad Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 464/2022 U/s 356/379/411/482/34 IPC at PS: Hari Nagar, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Asif can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Asif has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused Asif of FIR No. 464/2022 U/s 356/379/411/482/34 IPC of PS: Hari Nagar, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 06.06.2026.
By order
Moksha Bains
Judicial Magistrate First Class
West Court -31
DP/5367/WD/2026 Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
(SEE SECTION 82(2) (ii) Cr.P.C./84 BNSS)
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) Himanshu @ Kannu S/o Deepak R/o C-232, J.J. Colony, Wazirpur, Ashok Vihar, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 31052/2023, U/s 379/411 IPC, PS Keshav Puram, Delhi and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) Himanshu @ Kannu can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) Himanshu @ Kannu has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) Himanshu @ Kannu of case FIR No. 31052/2023, U/s 379/411 IPC, PS Keshav Puram, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated 21.09.2026.
By Order
Sanyam Jain
Judicial Magistrate First Class-04
Room No. 112, 1st Floor
Rohini Courts, Delhi
DP/5079/NW/2026 (Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 Cr.P.C.
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Mohit@Montu@Hemant S/o Jai Prakash R/o S-1/52, Budh Vihar Phase-1, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence FIR No. 105/2019 u/s 25 Arms Act at P.S. Vijay Vihar, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said Mohit@Montu@Hemant cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said Mohit@Montu@Hemant has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proceeding u/s 82 Cr.P.C. has been initiated in the case. Proclamation is hereby made that the said Mohit@Montu@Hemant accused of FIR No. 105/2019 u/s 25 Arms Act at P.S. Vijay Vihar, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on 30.05.2026.
By Order: Ms. Shagun,
Judicial Magistrate, First Class,
North-West Court No. 109, First Floor,
Rohini Courts, Delhi.
DP/5352/RD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Ajeet Kumar Rai, S/o Sh. Sachidanand, R/o Present Address - P-47, 2nd Floor, Pillanji Village, Sarojini Nagar, New Delhi and Permanent Address - VPO Mugaon, PS Kuran Sarai, District Buxer, Bihar has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 191/2021, U/s 307 IPC & 27 Arms Act, P.S. Sarojini Nagar, New Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said Ajeet Kumar Rai cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said Ajeet Kumar Rai has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).
Proclamation is hereby made that the said Ajeet Kumar Rai accused of FIR No. 191/2021, U/s 307 IPC & 27 Arms Act, P.S. Sarojini Nagar, New Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 03.07.2026.
By Order - Sh. Pitamber Dutt
Principal District & Session Judge Special Court (NIA)
Room No. 5, Main Building
Patiala House Courts, New Delhi
DP/5395/SW/2026

NORTHERN RAILWAY
E-TENDER NOTICE
Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer/Traction Distribution, DRM's Office, State Entry Road, New Delhi for & on behalf of President of India, invites open e-tender for the under noted work:-
Name of Work with its location: Manning of 05 Nos. Traction Substations over GZB-SRE and DSA-SMQL-SRE Sections of Delhi Division.
Approx. Cost of work ₹1,09,99,216.70 Date & Time of Pre-Bid Meeting 29.04.2026 (11:30 Hrs.)
Earnest Money Deposit ₹2,05,000/-
E-Tender Bid Online Submission Period 02.05.2026 (00:00 hrs.) to 16.05.2026 (13:00 hrs.)
E-Tender Bid Submission End Date & E-Tender Open Date & Time 16.05.2026 (13:00 hrs.)
Website particulars where complete details of tender documents can be seen www.ireps.gov.in
E-Tender No.: 06-TRD-NDLS-2026-27 Dated : 24.04.2026 1376/2026
SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
No. CEN-2026-27-02 Date: 22.04.2026
E-Tender Notice
The Dy. Chief Engineer/Const./North Central Railway/Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invite the following E-Tenders on prescribed form for the following works up to 15.00 hrs. on 19.05.2026. The details of the tenders are as under: -
SN. 1 Tender No.: CEN-2026-27-02 | Bid Security (₹): ₹ 4,47,400/-
Name of work: Third party inspection of Steel Girders for Railway Bridges, ROB, RFO and other steel fabrication work etc. for various projects of North Central Railway.
Approx. cost of work (₹): ₹ 2.23 Cr. (approx) | Completion period: 06 Months
Tender Closing Date & Time: 19.05.2026, 15:00 hrs, Date of Opening of tender: 19.05.2026 15:30 hrs., Type of tendering: Special Limited (Single Packet System).
Note: - 1. The complete information along with tender document of above E-Tenders are available on Website www.ireps.gov.in up to 15:00 hrs on the due date of tender opening i.e. 19.05.2026. 2. Bids other than in the form of E-bids shall not be accepted against above Tenders. For this purpose, vendors are required to get themselves registered with IREPS website along with Digital Signature Certificates issued by CCA under IT Act-2000. 3. The Bid Security shall be deposited either in cash through e-payment gateway or submitted as Bank Guarantee bond from a scheduled commercial bank of India or as mentioned in tender documents. The Bank Guarantee bond shall be as per format in favour of FA & CAO/INCR/PRYJ as given in Tender Document and shall be valid for a period of 90 days beyond the bid validity period. 4. Rates entered into Financial Rate page and duly signed digitally shall be considered. Rates and any other financial entity in any other form/letter head if attached by vendor shall be straight way ignored and shall not be considered. 5. Joint Venture (JV)/Consortiums/MOUs shall be considered for the tender having cost more than 10 Cr. 6. Documents being attached should be signed by the tenderer on its body. 7. The tenderers shall submit a certificate as given in tender document in standard format for all items without which their tender may not be considered and shall be summarily rejected. 8. Each page of the copy of documents/certificates in support of credentials, submitted by the tenderer, shall be self-attested/digitally signed by the tenderer or authorized representative of the tendering firm. Self-attestation shall include signature, stamp and date (on each page). Only those documents which are declared explicitly by the tenderer as "documents supporting the claim qualifying the laid down eligibility criteria", will be considered for evaluation his/her tender. In case of any wrong information submitted by the tenderer, the contract will be terminated, Bid Security (BS), Performance Guarantee (PG and Security Deposit (SD) of contract will be forfeited and agency will be banned for doing business on entire Indian Railways for two (02) years. 9. GST Act & rules issued from time to time by the Government authorities shall be applicable. 10. In case of any difficulty helpdesk available on the website of IREPS may be approached. 11. Tender online can be submitted up to 15.00 hrs. on 19.05.2026 and will be opened at 15.30 hrs. on same day. 887/26(DG)
North central railways @ CPRONCR www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
Tender Notice No: 0920262027 Dated: 22.04.2026
E-TENDER NOTICE
Divisional Railway Manager (Engineering)/ North Central Railway/Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites the following E-tender for the following work up to 13.30 hrs. on 20.05.2026. The details of the work is as under:
Tender No : 33 Approx Cost of work (Rs.) : 6,38,83,399.69
Name of Work : Through Sleeper Renewal-Primary (TSR-P) by Contractor's PQRS Portal and other miscellaneous work in Prayagraj-Kanpur section under the Jurisdiction of Sr. Divisional Engineer/II/Prayagraj.
Earnest Money (Rs.) : 12,77,700.00 Completion Period : 12 (Twelve) Months
Date of Opening of tender : 20.05.2026
Minimum Eligibility Criteria for "Similar work" : Any P-Way work".
* Note: 1: Similar Work for Minimum Eligibility Criteria: "Any P-Way Work". With Special condition in tender: Tenderer/Bidder will submit an affidavit of ownership of minimum 02 Nos. of PQRS/SQRS/TLE machines for working in running track during traffic block and 02 Nos. of Gantry for working in PQRS depot.
Note: 2: 1: E-Tender Forms shall be issued free of cost to all tenderers. 2: The complete information along with tender document of above E-Tenders are available on Website www.ireps.gov.in, up to 13:30 hrs. on the due date of tender opening i.e. 20.05.2026. 3: Bids other than in the form of E-Bids shall not be accepted against above tenders. For this purpose, vendors are required to get themselves registered with IREPS website along with Digital Signature Certificate issued by CCA under IT Act-2000. 4: Rates entered into Financial Rate page and duly signed digitally shall be considered. Rates and any other financial entity in any other form / letter head if attached by vendors shall be straightaway ignored and shall not be considered. 5: The tenderers shall submit a certificate as given in tender document as "Annexure" in standard format without which their tender may not be considered and shall be summarily rejected. 6: The supplier / contractor of goods and / or services would be subject to GST Act and Rules as applicable from time to time. 7: Document being attached should be signed by the tenderer on its body. 8: This tender notice has also been uploaded on www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in. 9: Payment of Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) in respect of e-tendering shall be accepted through net banking or payment gateway only. 10: In case of any difficulty helpdesk available on the website of IREPS may be approached. 11: Tender on line can be submitted up to 13.30 hrs. of tender opening date i.e. 20.05.2026. 12: The tenderer has to submit necessary documents in compliance of clause 10 to 18 (Part-I) of GCC-2022 mandatorily, otherwise offer will be considered as Incomplete Offer and accordingly shall not be considered. 902/26 (AS)
North central railways @ www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in @ CPRONCR

WEST CENTRAL RAILWAY
Tender Notice, Signal & Telecommunication Department
Sr.DSTE/CO/Kota acting for & On behalf of The President of India invites E-Tenders against No. KOTA/S&T/Tele/2026/01, KOTA/S&T/Tele/2025/18 and KOTA/S&T/Tele/2025/16 Date to open on 18.05.2026, 22.05.2026, 29.05.2026 and at 15:00 hrs. Manual offers are not allowed against this tender and any such manual offer received shall be ignored. S No. 1 Tender No. : KOTA/S&T/TE/LE/2026/01, Name of Work : Provision of Fiber Monitoring system in MTJ-NAGDA section of Kota Division , Approx. cost of the work : Rs. 18031339.15, Cost of Tender form : NIL, Earnest Money: 360700, Completion work : 12 Months, Last Date & Time of submission tender : 15:00 Hrs. on Date 18.05.2026, S No. 2 Tender No. : KOTA/S&T/TELE/2025/18 Name of Work : Provision of Control Monitoring System on VOIP based over KOTA-COR-RTA-section of Kota Division (WCR),. Approx. cost of the work : Rs. 29118104.57, Cost of Tender form : NIL, Earnest Money: Rs 582400, Completion work : 12 Months, Last Date & Time of submission tender : 15:00 Hrs. on Date 22.05.2026, S No. 3 Tender No. : KOTA/S&T/TELE/2025/16, Name of Work : Provision of Control Monitoring System on VOIP based over NAD- KOTA-MTJ section of Kota Division (WCR),. Approx. cost of the work : Rs. 51178302.48, Cost of Tender form : nil, Earnest Money: Rs 1023600, Completion work : 12 Months, Last Date & Time of submission tender : 15:00 Hrs. on Date 29.05.2026 The Tenders can be viewed at website www.ireps.gov.in. The tenderer/bidders must have class III Digital signature certificate & must be registered on IREPS portal. Only registered tenderer/bidders can participate in e-tendering. Also should have valid GSTIN.
Sd/-
Sr. DSTE (Co), West Central Railway, Kota
स्वच्छ भारत अभियान एक कदम स्वच्छता की ओर

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 Cr.P.C.
Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely Raj Singha S/o Badal Singha R/o (1) WZ 229, Gali No. 1, Tihar Village, Near Tandoor Chowk, Hari Nagar West, Delhi (2) WZ 28 GL-11, Krishna Puri Tiak Nagar, Mahabir Nagar, Delhi (3) Gurananak Pura, Haldwani Distt Nainital, Uttarakhand has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 56/2021 U/s 279/338 IPC PS: GTB Enclave, Delhi, and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Raj Singha cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Raj Singha has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).
Proclamation is hereby made that the said Raj Singha accused of FIR No. 56/2021 U/s 279/338 IPC PS: GTB Enclave, Delhi, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 09.06.2026.
By Order
Ms. Sanghmitra
JMFC-01, Room No. 54
Karkardooma Court, Delhi
DP/5419/SHD/2026 (Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 Cr.P.C.
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Mukesh @ Mungeri, S/o Harnam Singh, R/o 28/129, Kasturba Nagar, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 97/2020, U/s 392/411/34 IPC, P.S. Vivek Vihar, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said Mukesh @ Mungeri cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said Mukesh @ Mungeri has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).
Proclamation is hereby made that the said Mukesh @ Mungeri accused of FIR No. 97/2020, U/s 392/411/34 IPC, P.S. Vivek Vihar, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 04.06.2026.
By Order - Sh. Mohit Sharma
Chief Judicial Magistrate
Shahdara District, Room No. 59, 3rd Floor
Karkarduma Courts, Delhi
DP/5363/SHD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Omtosh Gange Srivastava, S/o. Shanbhu Sharan Srivastava, R/o.: C-69, JBTS Garden, Chhatrapur Extn., New Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in a case vide FIR No.148/2020 U/s 188 IPC & 332/461 DMC ACT registered at P.S Maidan Garhi, South District, New Delhi and it has been returned on a warrant of arrest thereupon issued stating that the said Omtosh Gange Srivastava could not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that accused Omtosh Gange Srivastava is absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).
Proclamation is hereby made that the said Omtosh Gange Srivastava, accused of FIR No. 148/2020 U/s 188 IPC & 332/461 DMC ACT, P.S. Maidan Garhi, South District, New Delhi is required to appear before the court to answer the said complaint on or before 03.06.2026.
By Order, Sh. Ashish Kumar Meena
Judicial Magistrate First Class-01 (South)
Room No.214, Saket Courts, New Delhi
DP/5327/SD/2026 (Court Matter)

AUTHOR



DIPANKAR DEY

In March 2026, a report titled “Torture and Genocide”, presented to the 61st session of the UN Human Rights Council, states that Israeli practices against Palestinians since October 7, 2023, may amount to genocide under the Convention on the Prevention and Punishment of the Crime of Genocide. Submitted by the UN Special Rapporteur on the situation of human rights in the Palestinian territories occupied since 1967, the report states that Israel’s detention system has developed into what it describes as a structure characterised by humiliation, coercion and systematic intimidation, aimed at stripping Palestinians of freedom, dignity and identity. It argues that these practices are not isolated incidents but reflect institutionalised policies with political backing.

Speaking on the UNHRC’s report on Israeli “Torture and Genocide”, the UN Special Rapporteur flagged legal and moral concerns for countries backing Israel. Responding to how she views India’s legal and moral responsibility by associating with Israel and its war, Ms Albanese said that while India is “violating its obligations” under International law, it might also be “facing responsibility”. “It seems to me that in the present, India and Israel are contributing to the decay of the international system that our forefathers or foremothers painfully built,” the UN special rapporteur on human rights in the Palestinian territories said.

The turning point of the three-millennium-old Jews’ history was the emergence of Zionism in the late 19th century as a political movement and the formation of a Jewish national home (1948) in Israel, which fundamentally altered the course of Jewish history from a ‘diaspora-focused existence’ to a ‘supremacist state’.

Birth of Zionism

Zionism is a political movement that gained traction among a minority of secular Jews only in the late 19th century. Zionists combined and reconciled many aspects of European fascism, white supremacy, colonialism, and messianic Evangelism, and had a long and sordid history of cooperating with anti-Semites, imperialists, and fascists to promote exclusivist and expansionist agendas. It is a racist and settler colonialist movement, which opportunistically co-opts aspects of Judaism in an attempt to justify its criminal practices of apartheid and genocide of indigenous Palestinians. White supremacy is dominant within Israeli society, which privileges white-skinned Ashkenazi Jews at the expense of dark-skinned African Jews, Sephardi and Mizrahi Jews, as well as African refugees. African/black Jewish communities are often denied recognition by Israeli authorities, with some members even deported.

The assertion that Zionism is essential to Jewish identity is misleading. Judaism is a monotheistic religion that is at least 3,000 years old, whereas Zionism began as a secular-led political movement in the late 19th century. For some, the Zionist movement and its progeny, the State of Israel, represent national liberation; the chance for Jews to rule themselves. For others, Zionism is a racist, colonial project. However, historians argue that the story of Jewish nationalism is more complex. Not all Jews are Zionists, and not all Zionists are Jews. Christian Zionists outnumber the Jew Zionists.

The root of Zionism can be traced to the Reformation movement in Europe. After the Protestant Reformation in the 16th century, there grew a renewed interest in reading and interpreting the Bible,

and resurgent millennial ideas regarded support of the Jews as a prerequisite to the coming of the Kingdom of God. In the mid-17th century, a shift toward Christian support for Jews happened predominantly in Anglophone Protestant contexts. In 1656, British statesman Oliver Cromwell, in partnership with Portuguese Jewish scholar Manasseh ben Israel, opened England to the return of the Jews, who had been expelled in 1290. Cromwell was inspired in part by a belief that the conversion of Jews to Christianity would expedite the Second Coming.

Austro-Hungarian journalist Theodor Herzl, in his 1896 pamphlet The Jewish State, argued that the establishment of a modern, European homeland for Jews would provide a refuge for a persecuted people and prevent competition with non-Jews. Antisemitism would disappear, and Jews would be able to ‘live at last as free men on our own soil’. In the years following the publication of The Jewish State, Argentina and East Africa would both be mooted as possible locations for the new homeland, but these territories lacked the draw of the Holy Land. Palestine – ‘our ever-memorable historic

home’ – was the dream. One year after the publication of The Jewish State, Herzl convened the First Zionist Congress (1897) in Basel and established the World Zionist Organisation (WZO). ‘Zionism seeks to establish a home for the Jewish people in Eretz Israel (Land of Israel) secured under public law’, declared the WZO. Zionism was now an organised movement of national liberation.

It is alleged that Israel’s current apartheid policies took shape in the lead-up to the Holocaust when Nazi Germany and a small group of influential Zionists formed a Nazi-Zionist alliance to build their ethno-nationalist states. The Haavara Agreement (named for the Tel Aviv company where the funds were transferred) of 1933, between Zionist organisations and Nazi Germany, facilitated the emigration of roughly 60,000 German Jews to Palestine and the transfer of their assets. It was endorsed by top Nazi officials, including Adolph Eichmann and Hitler and future Israeli prime ministers David Ben Gurion, Moshe Shertok, and Golda Meir. As part of the deal, the German Zionists also agreed to lobby the global Jewish community to end their boycott of German goods that began when Hitler came to power.

The Christian Zionists of the USA

After the establishment of Israel as a Jewish state in 1948, Christian Zionism took on a new form in America beginning in the 1960s with the rise of a newly revitalised Evangelical movement. The focus on returning Jews to Palestine shifted to political support for Israel. Evangelical leaders such as Billy Graham rejected persuading Jewish people to convert to Christianity and instead focused on supporting the Jewish people as having laid the foundation of Christianity and the creation of Israel as an important step towards the Second Coming. On 23 June 1969, at the Midtown Manhattan headquarters of the American Jewish Committee, Graham cited the Hebrew Scriptures, or Old Testament, to describe his understanding of God’s covenant with the Jewish people, and explained his support for Israel as recompense for past Christian anti-Judaism. ‘All Christians are guilty as far as Jewish experience was concerned’, he said. Graham also spoke of his conversations with the Israeli prime minister Golda Meir, and assured American Jewish leaders

that the United States’ president Richard Nixon was ‘extremely sympathetic’ to Israel.

Although many Christians – evangelical or otherwise – supported the creation of Israel before 1948, they cannot be called Christian Zionists in the modern parlance. Christian Zionism essentially fuses religious belief with a military, strategic, and even economic programme. Christian Zionism is not just the belief that the biblical land of Israel is the ordained country of the Jewish people, but that it is in America’s strategic, military, and economic interest to support the expansion of Israel. The largest population of Christian Zionists is in the US, and it numbers more than 30 million. Most are affiliated with evangelical churches in the southeast and south-central regions, often referred to as the “Bible Belt”. The biggest organisation is Christians United for Israel, which itself boasts 10 million members. Political analysts observe that Christian Zionists are overwhelmingly conservative Republicans and form one of the most formidable voting blocs in the Republican

FROM GAZA TO WASHINGTON TO NEW DELHI, THESE ALIGNMENTS ARE INFLUENCING POLICY, SHARPENING DIVISIONS AND extending their impact INTO REGIONS LIKE INDIA’S NORTHEAST, WHERE IDENTITY AND GEOPOLITICS INCREASINGLY OVERLAP

Party. United States Ambassador to Israel Mike Huckabee, a few weeks before the invasion of Iran, suggested that Israel has a God-given right to land stretching from the Euphrates River to the Nile, which would encompass Lebanon, Syria, Jordan, and parts of Saudi Arabia. Zionist Israel and Christian Zionists of the USA are natural allies.

By attempting to frame the current unlawful invasion of Iran as a ‘holy war’, leaders of Israel and the USA are using theological beliefs to “justify action, mobilise political opinion, and leverage support”, Jolyon Mitchell, a professor at Durham University in the UK, told.

A dangerous alliance

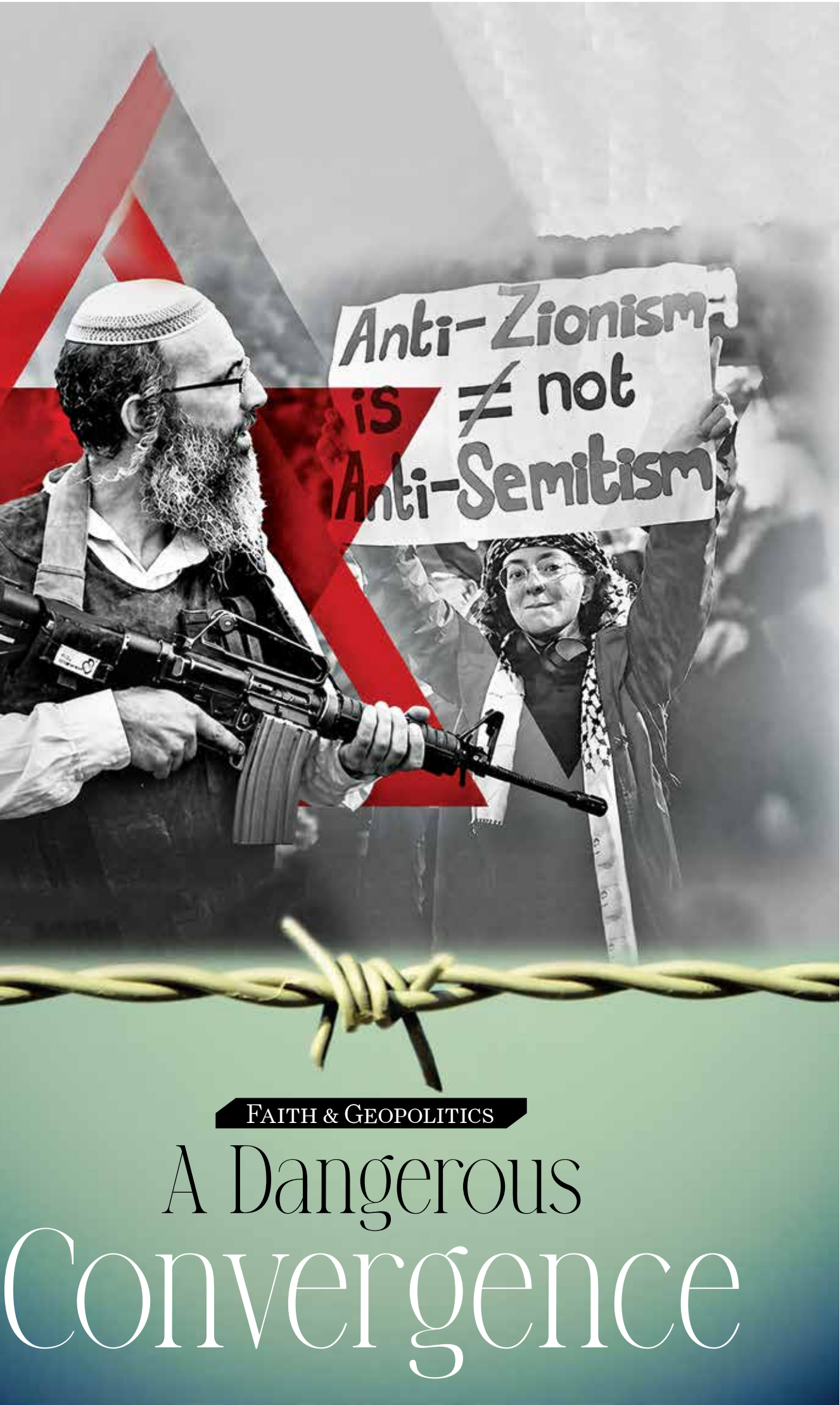
The Hindu nationalist government of India has aligned itself with Zionist Israel and its ally, the USA, which is currently led by Christian Zionist leaders. It may be recalled that during Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s state visit to Israel in February, he spoke to the Knesset, hailing India’s cultural, political, and military relationship with Israel. The visit also brought upgraded ties sealed with a “Special Strategic Partnership”.

Political analysts argue that Hindu nationalism and Zionism are ideological cousins. Hindutva, a Hindu nationalist ideology, was devised in the early 20th century, and Zionist solidarity sprang from the earliest Hindu nationalists who modelled their Hindu state on Zionism. Hindutva’s founder, Vinayak Damodar Savarkar, supported majoritarian nationalism and the rooting out of all disintegrating forces like Muslims and Christians. Savarkar praised Zionism as the perfection of ethno-nationalist thinking. The way Zionism seamlessly blended ethnic attachment to a motherland and religious attachment to a holy land was precisely what Savarkar wanted for the Hindus. This double attachment was far more powerful in his mind than the European model of “blood and soil” nationalism without sacred space. Today, Hindu nationalists perpetuate this legacy and look to Zionism as a uniquely attractive political ideology.

One particular sect of the Christian Kuki tribes claims Jewish lineage. As per Jewish belief, around 3000 years ago, ten tribes of the Northern Kingdom in Israel were forced into exile following an attack by the Assyrians. They are believed to have disappeared ever since. The Kukis are considered one such tribe, better known as Bnei Menashe, meaning the Children of the biblical Manasseh, the son of the prophet Joseph. The Kukis have long associated themselves with a variety of identities. Known to have migrated over centuries to India from the Chin State at the Myanmar border, the Chin-Kuki-Mizo (CHIKUMI) tribes largely follow Christianity. Last year, the Israeli Cabinet approved the immigration of all 5,800 Bnei Menashe residing in the North East region of India to Israel. On April 23, 2026, more than 250 Indians immigrants from the Bnei Menashe community landed at Ben Gurion airport as part of a government operation to relocate them to Israel.

The Bene Menashe Jews of Manipur have been caught in a deadly Meitei-Kuki ethnic conflict since 2023. The Zo peoples — comprising the Mizo, Kuki, Chin, and related tribes — share an unbroken ethnic, linguistic, and cultural heritage. But their contiguous highland homeland was arbitrarily dissected by the colonial Radcliffe Line and the India-Myanmar border. The Kukis have made a special demand for integrating all Kuki-Chin territories of Chin State (Myanmar), Chittagong Hill Tracts (CHT), Bangladesh, Mizoram (India), and the Kuki Hills in outer Manipur into one separate country, Zalemang (land of freedom).

The recent arrest of seven foreign citizens (six Ukrainians and one American) by Indian authorities has drawn attention to Myanmar-based ethnic armed organisations (EOs) and their links to India. The arrest of the US citizen Matthew VanDyke, best known for being a mercenary, an international security analyst, a combat veteran, a documentary filmmaker, and the founder of Sons of Liberty International (SOLI), reinforces the possibility of involvement of the US deep state in the ongoing ethnic conflict in Manipur. According to reports, in 2011, he joined Libyan rebel forces fighting against Muammar Gaddafi’s regime as a foreign fighter, fought against ISIS in Iraq, assisted uprisings in Syria, and joined Ukrainian forces against the Russian invasion starting in 2022. The uncaring attitude of the Indian government in dousing the Meitei-Kuki civil war in Manipur indicates a profane design.



FAITH & GEOPOLITICS

A Dangerous Convergence

BEYOND THE BATTLEFIELD, THE ISRAEL-PALESTINE CONFLICT REFLECTS A WIDER IDEOLOGICAL STRUGGLE WHERE FAITH, NATIONALISM AND POWER ARE SHAPING INTERNATIONAL RESPONSES AND STRATEGIC PARTNERSHIPS

Walking as a Way Within

In a hyperconnected world, the simple act of walking emerges as a powerful blend of fitness, mindfulness and quiet introspection for body and mind



AUTHOR



MITALI MADHUSMITA

The proponents of meditation, in its myriad forms, swear by it. These days, mindful meditation is the buzzword amongst the new generation as it helps them battle loneliness and stress. Yet, for the older generation born between the thirties and seventies of the last millennium, work was meditation, fuelled by the ideals of the *Bhagavad Gita*. They walked copious amounts everywhere they went for work, in any case. A daily walk has become the new mantra across the board nowadays. But have you considered a walk as a deeply personal meditative exercise? Consider these facts. A morning or evening walk of about 30–45 minutes is not just about exercise; it is a deeply contemplative and meditative activity. Every medical practitioner will tell you walking is one of the five pillars of a healthy lifestyle: the others being a balanced diet, at least 7–8 hours of sleep, keeping yourself stress-free, and having meaningful and positive relationships. Invariably, as most exercises go, different styles of walking have

evolved over the years. The latest is the IWT (Interval Walking Training), a 30-minute 3-3-3 routine alternating 3 minutes of brisk walking (heart rate 70%) followed by 3 minutes of slow walking (heart rate 40%), repeated five times. It is a Japanese practice aimed at improving metabolism, reducing visceral fat, and improving cardiovascular health more effectively than steady-state walking. The '6-6-6 routine' is 6 minutes of warm-up, followed by a 60-minute walk, ending with 6 minutes of cooling down. The '12-3-30 workout' (12% incline, 3.0 mph, 30 minutes) works as a low-impact, effective cardio routine for building endurance, strengthening the lower body, and burning calories, especially for beginners or those avoiding high-impact exercise. You could also choose to ignore all the above and simply focus on the walk at your own pace, which is 'the' most important thing. In polluted environments, this walk is best in the afternoons or before night sets in, as the air quality dips in the nights and early mornings. On such occasions, it can be fitted into the lunch break or post-office hours. For those of us having dual roles at home and in the office, it is a question of squeezing in time during the 24-hour window for a minimum half-an-hour walk. The extreme summer months force the body clock to awaken itself and go as early as possible. A walk starts off vigorously at first when you focus on loosening exercises and the movement of your feet. At this point in time and space, as daylight



WALK YOUR WAY

From the disciplined 3-3-3 interval routine to the popular 12-3-30 treadmill workout, walking styles continue to evolve. But experts agree: consistency matters more than method. Whether brisk or slow, structured or free-flowing, the best walk is the one that fits seamlessly into your daily life.

slowly breaks, you become acutely aware of your own breath and of your tiny space in the microcosm of the universe. Then, as you take in the sights and sounds, it tends to meander and stretch into a higher level of awareness. The stress lets go as muscles tighten, and you focus on the here and now. You notice the budding leaves, barely visible, peeping out of the

skeletal branches opening to the sky. The first call of the cuckoo reminds you that summer has come prematurely. You try to spot the insistent but deeply reclusive creature. Depending on the season, you can hear the mating calls of birds, peacocks, monkeys, and squirrels, or whatever other living creatures inhabit your part of the universe. The morning dew often prompts the walker to take off the shoes and walk barefoot on the grass. As the sun makes its appearance, the dappled sunlight and the green spaces impact the mind, activating dopamine and serotonin—neurotransmitters that elevate the mood. You break out of repetitive, negative rumination and arrive at renewed attention and can centre on the 'present'.

There is a reason why our saints and evolved men are said to have escaped into the outdoors and the forests from the rigours of daily life,

even when they had all that they needed and more. Royal princes such as Siddhartha, Mahavir, Rama, and the Pandavas left their palatial mansions for the refuge of green forests, although they were replete with the dangers of the unknown. Stories about India's holy people are replete with accounts of wandering. Ever wondered why? From the outside, wandering and meditating may appear contradictory, but like speech and silence, they are complementary. The Buddha walked all day and meditated at dawn and in the evening. Ramakrishna Paramahansa talks of two kinds of seekers: 'kutichaka' and 'bahudaka'. Kutichakas live in huts, immersed in meditation. Bahudakas roam the world in search of experience. True knowledge comes only from a meaningful combination of wandering and meditation. Walking is a way of mingling with people, of imbibing and imparting shared ideas and knowledge. An unfiltered walk in the outdoors, instead of in a gym or connected to your gadgets, is your time to disconnect. In today's chaotic world, we are constantly harangued by notifications, calls, emails, messages, and thoughts that do not give time for quiet reflection and to be with our own selves. A walk is the simplest and easiest way to a good lifestyle. To put it succinctly, you are 'what you eat', 'how you move', and 'what you think'.

BEYOND FITNESS ROUTINES AND *step counts*, WALKING OFFERS SOMETHING DEEPER—A CHANCE TO RECONNECT WITH THE SELF

AUTOMOBILES



1

YEAR WAIT-LISTS



2

ICONS RELOADED



4X4

FEVER GROWING



Mojo Machines

Written off many, many moons ago as dated and dithering, Mahindra Auto has roared back ferociously. Its SUVs aren't just bought, they're obsessively desired

AUTHOR



RAJEEV NARAYAN

It is a rugged return. I remember a time, not too long ago, when Mahindra & Mahindra looked like a company caught between nostalgia and irrelevance. Its rugged DNA, forged in the era of the original Jeep-inspired workhorses, seemed out of place in a market chasing sleek urban crossovers and gadget-laden cabins. Mahindra Auto's products felt dated, the design language uninspired and the excitement largely missing. Then, quite abruptly, Mahindra Auto flipped the narrative on its head. So much so, that it is not merely selling SUVs today; it is selling aspirations, dreams and testosterone wrapped in steel, torque and waiting periods long enough to test a buyer's patience. And loyalty. The launch of the ScorpioN, That Roxx and XUV 7XO did more than boost sales charts; they reignited a brand that had begun to fade into the background noise of India's hyper-competitive automobile market.

PLAY ON SCARCITY

If there is one unmistakable

sign of Mahindra's resurgence, it is the queues inside and outside its showrooms, and the weather be damned. This is not metaphorical, but real, with waiting periods stretching across months, sometimes over a year. In an industry space where instant gratification is the norm, Mahindra has done something counterintuitive. It has made customers wait. And it has made them like the waiting.

This is not accidental. Analysts have often pointed out that constrained supply, whether by design or circumstance, has amplified desirability. A report by analysts noted how the long waiting periods for the XUV 7XO, Thar Roxx and ScorpioN created a halo effect, elevating all three models into aspirational territory. In a curious twist, delay became demand's new best friend. Eulogy aside, scarcity alone does not sell cars; it only sharpens appetite. What Mahindra has managed to do (arguably better than most) is ensure that the product justifies the anticipation. When buyers finally take delivery, the experience validates the hype. Most of the time.

A LEAP IN DESIGN

The real pivot lies beneath the surface. Mahindra's investments in engineering, design and global talent are paying off in ways that even sceptics find hard to dismiss. The XUV 7XO marked a decisive break from some previous, awkward design experiments. It is bold but not brash, and modern without losing identity.

The ScorpioN managed the impossible, reinventing an icon without alienating its loyal base. Thar Roxx made the capable but uncomfortable road-chewer Thar grow some sexy entrails after a fresh round of manicure, pedicure and enema. Worldwide, such balancing acts between legacy and reinvention have seen many automakers stumble. Mahindra has not.

Industry observers have credited this transformation to an integrated product development approach, with inputs from global design studios and a sharper focus on consumer expectations. The result is a line-up that no longer feels like it is playing catch-up. Instead, it sets benchmarks... be it in road presence, feature lists or sheer visual drama.

THE WAR OF FEATURES

Step inside any Mahindra SUV and the shift becomes apparent. Panoramic sunroofs, advanced driver assistance systems, connected tech, etc.

etc. These features were once considered the preserve of plush imports; they are now part of the Mahindra vocabulary. The XUV 7XO's inclusion of Advanced Driver Assistance Systems (ADAS) was a particularly telling move. It signalled intent. Mahindra was not content with being rugged and no-frills. It wanted to compete (and win) on technology as well.

Yet, this is where the story becomes nuanced. For all its strides, Mahindra's execution has not been flawless. Early software glitches, niggling quality issues and inconsistent after-sales experiences have occasionally dented the sheen. In a market where word-of-mouth travels faster than any marketing campaign, these are not trivial concerns.

The company seems aware of this lump in its customers' throats. Recent efforts to streamline service networks and improve customer engagement suggest a recognition that product excellence must

be matched by ownership experience. Whether that gap closes enough remains to be seen.

A NATION OF SUVs

Mahindra's resurgence is a story about India itself. After all, this is a country that has fallen head over heels for SUVs, real or imagined. From urban commuters to rural buyers, the SUV has become a symbol of status, safety and, occasionally,

MAHINDRA'S SUVs HAVE REIGNED DESIRE, BUT WHEN POWER FUELS ROAD *arrogance*, ANY BRAND'S HARD-EARNED MOJO RISKS TURNING INTO A TROUBLING MENACE



stubborn practicality. Mahindra has tapped into this sentiment. Its vehicles are not just modes of transport; they are statements. They promise capability, even if most will never see a dirt trail, and project a rugged masculinity that resonates across demographics.

In doing so, Mahindra has outmanoeuvred competitors who either underestimated the emotional pull of SUVs or diluted it in pursuit of broader appeal. While others chased volume through compromise, Mahindra doubled down on identity.

The question now is whether this mojo is sustainable, or if it was just a well-timed surge. For the challenges are real. Electrification is no longer a distant prospect but an ongoing disruption. Sure, Mahindra has made ambitious noises, outlining plans for a new generation of electric SUVs, but ambition is the easy part. Execution is where legacies are made or broken, as global auto giants have shown us over the years.

And competition is intensifying. Rivals are not standing still. From Korean giants refining their offerings to Chinese EVs and American muscle recalibrating strategies for India, the battlefield is getting quite crowded. There is also the risk of complacency, the silent killer of resurgence stories. The very success that Mahindra enjoys today could, if unchecked, breed the same inertia that once dragged it down.

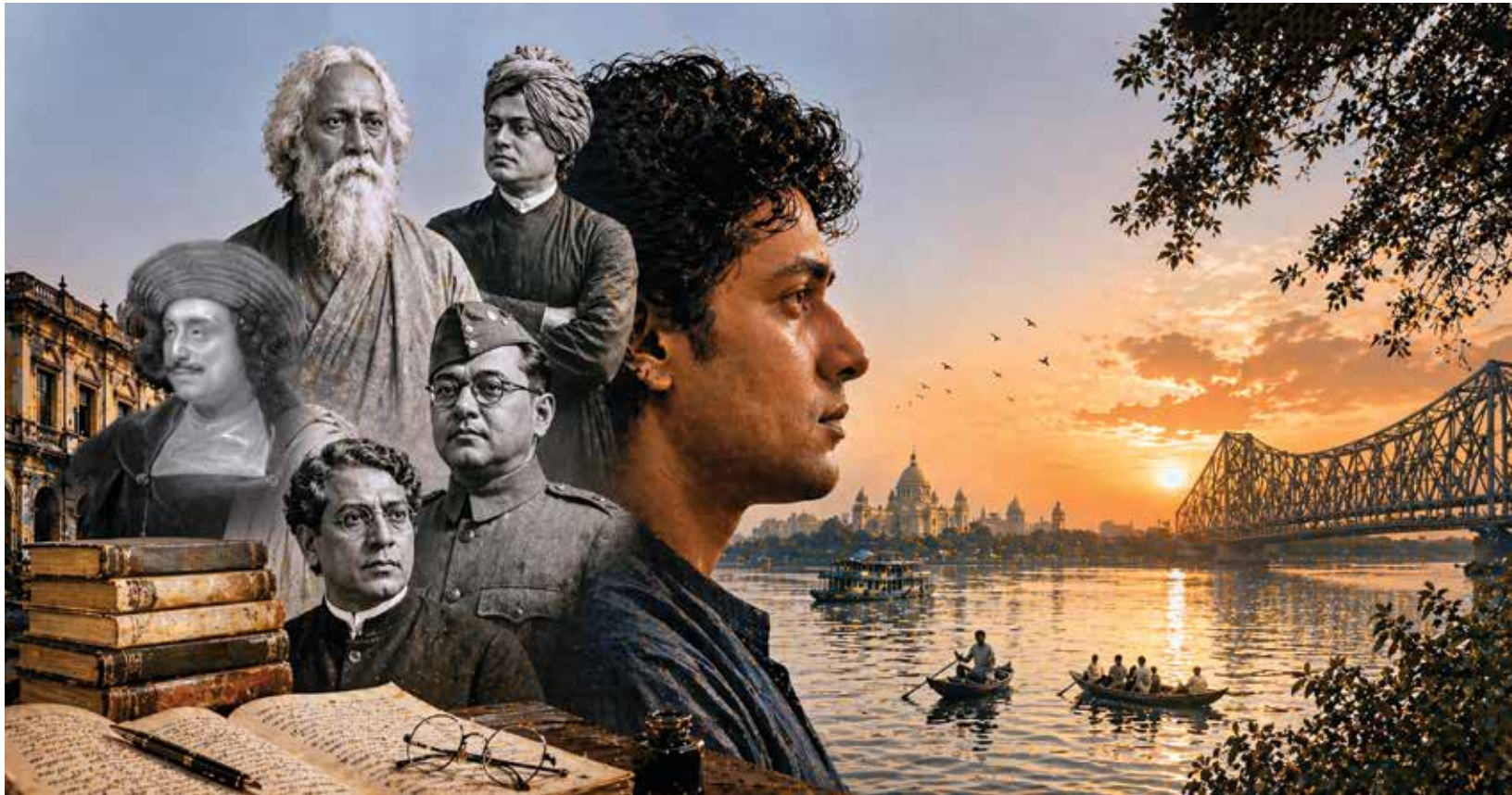
WILL THE U-TURN LAST?

For now, the verdict seems to be that Mahindra Auto has pulled off a most compelling turnaround. It has rediscovered its voice, sharpened its identity and reconnected with the Indian buyer's psyche. But the road ahead will demand more than momentum. It will require discipline, consistency and the humility and foresight to keep evolving.

For in the unforgiving world of automobiles, mojo is not a destination. It is a moving target. For Mahindra, the test is not whether it got its groove back, but whether it can keep driving it forward.

Soliloquy: A footnote has to be added here. Thar and ScorpioN have become protagonists in 'street theatre' across India. There are viral videos of dangerous overtakes, reckless intimidation and a near-feudal sense of entitlement on roads. It would be silly to blame the machine for the misdemeanour, but it is also true that when a brand begins to symbolise aggression along with aspiration, the line between rugged appeal and road menace blurs. For Mahindra and India's car culture, this is a message: Power, mechanical or social, must come with restraint. On roads as crowded and chaotic as India's, the true mark of a machine is not how it dominates, but how responsibly it is driven.

Mapping the Bengali Mind



Through literary insight and sociological depth, Alapan Bandyopadhyay's *Bangalir Mon* explores the making—and possible unmaking—of the Bengali mind across generations and geographies

AUTHOR

SUBHORANJAN DASGUPTA

Professor Amal Bhattacharjee, a magisterial teacher of English Literature, was delivering a lecture on Robert Browning's *The Last Ride Together*. After an analysis in impeccable English for one full hour, the creaseless dhoti- and Punjabi-clad Amalbabu switched over to chaste Bengali and said, "Ebare barite phire Rabindranather Sesh Basanto poro." I recalled this experience fervently, going back to the sixties of the last century at Presidency College, while I read *Bangalir Mon*, an excellent exploration of the Bengali psyche and weltanschauung as it developed and also declined. Why? Because Amalbabu's words crystallised the depth and diversity, as well as the dependence and inheritance, of the Bengali bhadralok. A dual inheritance, in fact, which sought its sustenance from the *Charyapada* and John Donne, simultaneously.

I wondered: how could an ever-busy bureaucrat like Alapan write this scholarly exegesis on such a complex and sensitive subject? How could he find the time for reading almost all scholars exploring this realm, from Sabyasachi Bhattacharya to Joya Chatterji, to mention only two? My second question is not unrelated—how could he be so interdisciplinary, with a missionary zeal, delving into history, literary texts, political theory, and social philosophy so effortlessly? He has woven all these threads into a single, masterly web.

First, I come to the literary texts to which he has devoted many pages, because I am myself a student of the legendary Professor Tarakanath Sen. Let me claim, with all possible candour at my command, that the author's explication of Apu's destiny in *Pather Panchali*, scarred by the deaths of his dearest ones, and Debu Pandit's transformation into a vibrant, rural political leader in Panchagram are two superb examples of the sociological treatment of creativity. I have only one question—wouldn't we have welcomed his dissection of *Putul Nacher Itikatha* as well, where Sashi, tormented by vacillation in that obscure, muddy village Gaodia, is also another

example of the variant *Bangalir Mon*? Like Devdas and Apu, the Bengali protagonist traverses uninterruptedly; but, at the same time, he gets inescapably stuck, like Sashi and even like Srikanta—who is by far the most popular hero in Bengali literature. Recall his standing rooted to the platform, not knowing where to proceed when the train with his last heartthrob, Kamallata, departs. Let me indulge in some epistemic mischief and extend the logic further—the illustrious Bengali mind, nurtured by Claude Henri de Saint-Simon and Swami Vivekananda, can also get lamentably stuck in the suicidal cobwebs of erroneous Marxian praxis and alarmingly hyped Hindutva, which is intrinsically different from Hinduism.

What helps us to get out of this quagmire of double obscurantism is redemptive poetry, and I think



A DEEPLY LAYERED ENGAGEMENT WITH BENGAL'S intellectual TRADITION, TRACING HOW MEMORY, LITERATURE AND POLITICS SHAPE—and FRACTURE—THE BENGALI PSYCHE ACROSS TIME

Alapan could have given some more attention to the post-Tagorian poets, from Jibanananda Das to Samar Sen. Yes, Sudhindranath Dutta is difficult to comprehend at times, but I shall borrow the word '*Duruha*' (difficult) from Buddhadeva Bose and not '*durbodhya*' (incomprehensible) in this context. Similarly, a handful of poems by Bishnu Dey are undeniably loaded with terms that baffle. But, by and large, his poems from *Baise June* to *Smriti Satta Bhabishyat* are eminently understandable and also an ardent creative record of those turbulent times. Above all, Jibanananda evocatively expressed the excruciating agony of the forties in incomparable verse. No historical document invokes the hellish conflagration of communal devastation like his immortal elegy *Chechollish-Satchollish* (1946–47). Perhaps, Alapan would devote some more pages to Bengali poetry, as he had done with the novel, in the second edition, because no

other idiom reveals the Bengali mind better than its irrepressible lyrical aporia, its despair, and its divinity.

The author has remained true to the kindred points of heaven and home. He has meticulously detailed the precious elements that have enriched the Bengali mind and also emphasised its severe demographic confinement, which is proceeding apace. The latter is elaborated in detail. Indeed, the figures that he tables are beyond question, and we are almost provoked to ask the very disturbing query—is the Bengali *bhadralok*, embodying the Bengali mind, ebbing out in the increasing welter of Namasudras, low castes, adivasis, Motuas, and the bucolic? No harm if it does ebb, because it has played its historic role, and I doubt if it will determine the sociopolitical future of the state passing through the tense phase of the election.

Appropriately enough, Alapan has referred to the existential quality in Bangladesh. And here I would like to raise a query. Could we address the secular and educated—in a word, the enlightened—Bangladeshi also as '*bhadralok*', along with the conventional address '*janab*'? Is there any intrinsic difference between Sankha Ghosh and Shamsur Rahman, Ghulam Murshed and Sisir Kumar Das, Zainul Abedin and Paritosh Sen? Should we have any hesitation in labelling Kazi Abdul Odud as *bhadralok*? In order to answer this penetrating question, we have to read Alapan's revealing chapters on Partition and perhaps conclude with Akhtaruzzaman Elias's indictment: "The Partition was so meaningless and disastrous." It broke the Bengali mind, notwithstanding the obviously different histories of the two communities from the thirties of the last century, into two seemingly antagonistic pieces. I salute Elias as the most brilliant Bengali novelist of our contemporary moment, who is literally adored in both Bengals.

Obvious constraints of space compel me to exclude other thought-provoking themes like *Udbastur Mon* (Mind of the Refugee), *Narir Mon* (Mind of the Woman), *Shikkhaker Mon* (Mind of the Teacher), and others. These will be explored in a longer review in an academic journal later.

But let me end by recollecting the extremely revealing dialogue between Noam Chomsky and the author, which forms the conclusion. The most crucial comment made by Chomsky was: "On the one hand, many are underlining the importance of European unity. But, on the other hand, resisting this continental pressure, regional and even local languages are flowering as a mark of protest against this linguistic homogeneity." Memory assails. Like Alapan, I also accompanied Chomsky on a trip, though state-sponsored, which showed him the fruits of the panchayati system in my state, sown by the then regime. Once the journey ended, I asked him, "You are an unequivocal anarchist by conviction. In that case, wouldn't it have been better if you had avoided this guided tour and explored our villages all by yourself?" Chomsky did not answer; he only gave an indulgent smile.

Alapan, heartfelt thanks—you have set the readers thinking in our post-truth and demeaning world of Artificial Intelligence and Goebbelsian fabrication.

Preserving a Sacred Continuum

Biswarup Mukherjee's *Ramakrishna Math O Mission* explores the *Ramakrishna Math and Mission* through memory, place and the quiet labour of preservation

AUTHOR

ADITYA GOLE

Writing about Sri Ramakrishna and the movement that grew around his life and teachings is never a neutral literary exercise. It demands not only familiarity with history but also sensitivity to a living tradition that continues to shape spiritual and cultural life in Bengal. In *Ramakrishna Math O Mission: Abahaman Sebabroto*, Biswarup Mukherjee approaches this challenge with a commendable balance of research, restraint and quiet devotion.

The author's credentials lend credibility to the project. A former journalist turned public relations professional and a writer with experience across essays, fiction and poetry, he brings both documentary rigour and literary poise to the subject. His earlier engagement with institutional and cultural history is evident throughout the book, which feels less like a retelling and more like a carefully assembled narrative.

What distinguishes this work is its method. Rather than attempting an expansive, sweeping history of the Ramakrishna Math and Mission, the author chooses a more grounded and textured approach. The structure of the book suggests a deliberate movement from the broad idea of the Mission as a 'timeless vow of service' to the specific lived contexts in which the ideals were structured.

Central to this approach is the author's attention to place. The narrative repeatedly returns to historical places associated with Sri Ramakrishna and the early movement - Shyampukur, Atpur and Baranagar among others. These are not treated as mere background settings, but as

active carriers of memory. In particular, the detailed focus on Shyampukur Bati and the history of its restoration, along with the work of the Sri Ramakrishna Smaran Sangha, reveals a dimension often overlooked in broader institutional histories - the labour of preservation.

This emphasis is one of the book's most compelling contributions. Mukherjee implicitly expands the meaning of '*seva*' (service), the central ideal of the Ramakrishna Mission. Service here is not confined to well-documented activities such as education, medical relief or disaster response. It also includes the quieter, less visible work of safeguarding memory - of restoring buildings, maintaining sites and sustaining associations that keep history alive. In this sense, the book reads as an act of archival devotion, where remembrance itself becomes a form of service.

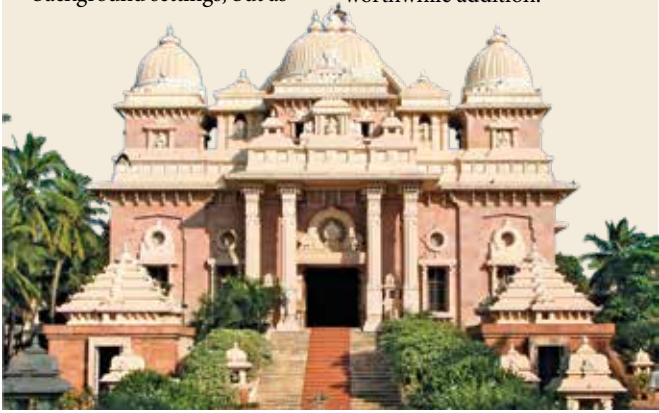
At the same time, the book remains attentive to the larger historical arc of the Ramakrishna movement. It traces, albeit without overstatement, the transition from the intensely personal spiritual presence of Sri Ramakrishna to the organised, institutional form given to his ideals by Swami Vivekananda through the founding of the Ramakrishna Math and Mission in 1897. This shift - from lived experience to structured continuity - is handled with clarity and thoughtfulness.

Mukherjee's prose supports the subject well. It is clear, measured and accessible, avoiding both the dryness of purely academic writing and the excesses of uncritical devotional language. There is warmth in the narrative, but it is tempered by an awareness of historical detail and context.

Ultimately, *Ramakrishna Math O Mission: Abahaman Sebabroto* succeeds in reminding us that spiritual institutions are not sustained by ideas alone. They endure through places, people and acts of care - often uncelebrated, but essential. For readers interested in the Ramakrishna tradition not just as philosophy but as lived and preserved history, this book is a thoughtful and worthwhile addition.



THE BOOK SUCCEEDS IN REMINDING US THAT spiritual INSTITUTIONS ARE NOT SUSTAINED BY IDEAS ALONE



RELEVANCE REVISITED

As Bengal negotiates demographic shifts, political churn, and cultural realignment, questions around the relevance of the bhadralok have resurfaced. **Alapan Bandyopadhyay's** *Bangalir Mon* enters this debate by revisiting the intellectual foundations of that identity—and asking whether it still shapes the region's future.



Reading India's T20 Future

With the IPL exposing leadership strengths and flaws, India's T20 captaincy debate intensifies—placing Shreyas Iyer firmly in contention for the 2028 vision

AUTHOR



S KANNAN

The chatter over a change of captaincy in the Indian T20 national team is happening at the right time. With the Indian Premier League (IPL) fever peaking, what with temperatures rising across India, it is a good time to reflect on the current leadership. Suryakumar Yadav, who led India to the ICC T20 World Cup win earlier this year, has almost forgotten what batting is. Such is his plight that, today, he can consider himself lucky to be a part of the Mumbai Indians playing XI. The outfit under Hardik Pandya struggles, and the middle-order muddle has seen Surya perform poorly.

Surya has become a talking point for many reasons. The man who spoke of wanting to lead India till 2028, notably till the Olympics in Los Angeles, where cricket is a medal sport, now finds no role for himself, even as a pure batter. The fact is, Suryakumar Yadav has lost form and supporters in Indian cricket today. Sadly, if fans thought Axar Patel, his deputy, could have taken over the mantle, that does not seem to be happening.

For all those who are following the highs and lows in the IPL this season, it is clear that the way Shreyas Iyer is performing is being talked about everywhere. A rough glance at the leadership styles of various franchises in the IPL shows that Shreyas has forged a great partnership with coach Ricky Ponting at Punjab Kings. Of course, massive credit also goes to team owner Preity Zinta, whose energetic presence and smiles are disarming. She has, indeed, also been exemplary in how a team owner must behave in the public domain.

First things first, everyone involved in Indian cricket must accept that Shreyas Iyer has been wronged. Just to jog the readers' memory, this Mumbaier has been a bit of an enigma as to why he did not play more for India. Test cricket is as good as over for him, but, certainly, in the white-ball format, Shreyas is not just a good prospect but the right candidate with the right credentials to lead in the T20 format. Add to it his obvious selection in the ODI format, and it adds weight to Shreyas.

Why Shreyas has not been part of the national T20 squad is something the BCCI can best answer. Now that Ajit Agarkar has been given an extension as chairman of the BCCI selection committee till 2027, keeping in mind the ODI World Cup to be held in South Africa, the former fast bowler needs to watch closely. Sadly, Axar Patel's elevation does not seem to be on the cards. He has been defensive as the captain of the Delhi Capitals. To hold himself back against Sunrisers Hyderabad on Tuesday, when Abhishek Sharma was belting the ball in all arcs with vengeance, is a clear sign that Patel was not ready

to challenge him.

As it were, bowlers in the IPL are scared of bowling to these modern-day, Rambo-type batters. Look at the way Abhishek Sharma (Sunrisers Hyderabad), Tilak Varma (Mumbai Indians), the boys from Punjab Kings (Priyansh and Prabhsimran), and RCB captain Rajat Patidar bat—they are simply fearless. Forget just the strike rate, which they have to show. When these batters get going, it's a challenge to bowl to them. Patidar has been very consistent in domestic cricket and has taken to captaincy at RCB with relish. There is still a long way to go in this IPL, but he can be looked at as someone who should be playing for India regularly. After all, the big picture is 2028.

Some time back, there were murmurs about whether Shubman Gill should also be in the T20 mix. As captain of the Gujarat Titans, he definitely does not seem to be the right choice as the future captain of India in the T20 format. He can handle the Test team and ODIs, provided the BCCI does not come up with any surprising decisions.

There are many aspects that need to be looked at while naming the Indian T20 captain. Definitely, having someone who can play both the ODI and T20 internationals will be an important factor to consider. Shreyas not being picked for the T20 internationals and two successive ICC T20 World Cups is a mistake which can be corrected by the BCCI.

For the sheer volume of cricket to be played in the next two years, especially in the T20 format, there is a need for a captain who sets an example.

PBKS REWRITE T20 HISTORY

Shreyas Iyer's unbeaten 71 off 36 balls was a measured, timely contribution in a high-scoring thriller, guiding Punjab Kings through a record chase of 265. While the platform was laid by an explosive start, Iyer ensured there were no late hiccups, mixing caution with calculated aggression. Not flawless, given the dropped chances, but his composure and game awareness proved decisive in closing out a remarkable contest.

604
RUNS LAST SEASON SET
THE TONE FOR IYER, NOW
HAMMERING 279 RUNS AT
186 STRIKE RATE

INDIA'S T20
FUTURE CANNOT BE
BUILT ON REPUTATION
ALONE. IT MUST REST ON FORM,
temperament
AND CLARITY—QUALITIES THE
IPL IS CURRENTLY PUTTING
UNDER THE SPOTLIGHT

Feedback on Shreyas is that he is a positive captain and gives the boys enormous freedom at the Punjab Kings. Hang on—his rise as a captain in franchise cricket did not happen overnight. For those who will talk of 'differences' existing between him and the present coach Gautam Gambhir, Shreyas was the one who took over the mantle of the Delhi franchise when Gambhir had chucked captaincy after a string of losses in the 2018 season. Shreyas led Delhi for three years, with an entry into the IPL final in 2020 deflating his tenure. Delhi lost to Mumbai Indians in the final.

After that, Shreyas moved to Kolkata Knight Riders in 2022 as captain. Having been laid low by a back injury, he missed the 2023 IPL season. The way Shreyas bounced back in 2024 and led KKR to the IPL title win against Sunrisers Hyderabad was massive. Interestingly, Gambhir was mentor of KKR at that point in time, before becoming the national coach in July 2024. It will be interesting if the BCCI looks at pairing Shreyas with Gambhir, a coach who is riding on a high. Forget all talk of bad blood between

Shreyas and Gambhir—the star batter and most sought-after captain in franchise cricket is a professional. Shreyas has worked with coaches smoothly, with the current two years alongside Ricky Ponting now being discussed openly.

For those who have seen Shreyas deliver, his batting and leadership apart, his fielding standards and 'catching' have been sublime. Despite the injuries, which have been an integral part of his career, he has bounced back stronger each time. Carefree and someone who goes with the flow, Shreyas has never talked of having been wronged by the BCCI. This defines him as a human and a cricketer who does not talk of bad luck. He appears the best choice for 2028, what with the T20 World Cup and LA Olympics looming.

One man who should have been pressing his case for a leadership role in the white-ball format is Rishabh Pant. To blame bad luck will not help, even as Pant's list of injuries is growing. He has no place in the ODI squad or T20 squad today for Team India. At Lucknow Super Giants, Rishabh Pant has not done anything noteworthy. This is his second season in Lucknow, and time is running out for Pant. On paper, no comparison can be made between Rishabh Pant and Shreyas Iyer, as a batter or captain. As things stand, Pant should consider himself lucky if he can cling on to his place in the Test squad. For how long, none knows.

Away from the thick and serious action of the IPL, one icon continues to grab headlines and dominate social media as well. Yes, even in absentia, MS Dhoni has been talked about repeatedly. Ruled out for the first three weeks-plus in the IPL 2026 edition due to a calf injury, Dhoni flew to Hyderabad and then Mumbai. Videos of him batting in the nets and keeping wickets have created a flutter. Someone like Sanjay Manjrekar saying that Dhoni is spoiling things for CSK was not in good taste. Dhoni remains important for CSK as a talisman. He is not just another player—that is the message from the franchise bosses. If Dhoni still attracts crowds and forces security personnel at airports to be on their toes, it is his charisma.

Inside the arena, Dhoni inspires awe, with CSK players ready to touch his feet. So, let the Dhoni mystique not be questioned. He is there because the CSK management wants him as a lucky charm, a real-life hero who refuses to fade away. Such aura and stage presence were witnessed when Diego Maradona was alive. In football today, Lionel Messi and CR7 still command the same respect.

Dhoni has given up international cricket, but as far as the IPL is concerned, he still stays involved. Anyone wishing he should leave the CSK franchise has no clue what the romance is between the 'Whistle Podu' gang and Thala Dhoni. In a rough comparison, evergreen Tamil movie star Rajinikanth still enjoys such adulation, well past his prime.

INLAND

DECODING CLIMATE MODELS



From equations and grids to uncertainty and probability, climate models offer powerful insights into Earth's future—but they remain approximations shaped by limits of science and computing

AUTHOR



KRISHNA GUPTA

In the last two articles, we discussed the hierarchy of various climate models, starting from simple zero-dimension Energy Balance Models to the complex General Circulation Models (GCMs) and Earth System Models (ESMs). However, constructing models, running simulations, and then interpreting the results is far from simple. Further, each model and its simulations lead to different pathways. In climate models, one is dealing with many probability distributions, and climate change is essentially a change in these distributions. Finally, the global climate model is just that: a simplified representation of the real world in the form of thousands of equations and millions of variables. The reality may be quite different. Let us discuss these issues in more detail here.

THE BASICS OF CLIMATE MODEL BUILDING

Most climate models are based on the fundamental laws of physics and chemistry and simulate the process of transfer of energy, gases, and matter through various parts of the climate system. These fundamental laws include the laws of conservation of energy and conservation of mass, Newton's second law of motion, and the ideal gas law (which defines the relationship between the pressure, volume, and temperature of a gas). These models divide the Earth into three-dimensional grids, with each grid having specified variables such as temperature, pressure, density, wind speed, etc. Based on the fundamental laws of physics, each grid is characterised by a set of equations that describe how these variables change over a period of time. This period of time is called a 'time step' and can vary from a few seconds to hundreds of years, but is typically 10 minutes; which means that the model produces calculations for each grid every 10 minutes. Inter-grid exchange of matter and energy takes place in the model to approximate real-

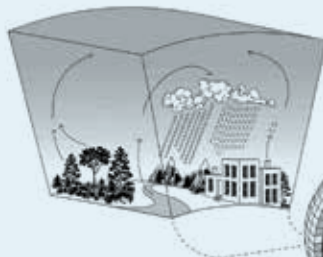
world processes. Each grid is typically 100 km by 100 km, though smaller grids are being developed with the rise in computational power.

The climate model solves the equations for each grid based on present values; this process is repeated for the next time period, and these iterations continue until a future point that one wishes to analyse and predict is reached. GCMs and ESMs solve millions of such equations to predict the climate over large periods (100 years or projections up to the year 2100). A climate model is run and tested through a process called 'hindcasting'. This requires the specification of initial conditions (for example, many models specify the pre-industrial conditions of 1850 as a starting point to measure the effects of greenhouse gases on the rise in temperature over the past centuries). The model run provides outputs of various important variables such as changes in temperature or sea levels, etc. Various simulations can also be run with the model to help guide decision-makers in policy-making.

It is important to note here that the time step is an important constraint while running models. Many GCMs use a 10-minute time step to enable them to deal with high-resolution detail such as local weather (for example, hurricanes). What is gained in high-resolution detail is often offset by limitations in how far into the future predictions can extend. Ultimately, a balance has to be struck between geographical resolution, timeframe, and computing resources.

Climate models are, of course, tools in a climate scientist's armoury and are used to study the climate system and climate change. They are, however, only the first step. There are still many issues that need to be resolved, such as greenhouse gases, clouds, rainfall, and thunderstorms, which are not fully captured by the equations in each grid box. The way to address these limitations is through 'parameterisation', which we will discuss below. There is also the issue of modelling the oceans, including their surface temperature, salinity, and ocean currents.

It may be noted that the climate system and climate change are very different: the climate system refers to the climate of all the interconnected components such as the Earth, atmosphere, land, oceans, and ice sheets as they exist. As David Stainforth has suggested in his book Predicting Our Climate Future, climate change has many aspects, ranging from climate prediction to extrapolation, probabilities of outcomes (as he notes: "Climate change is a one-shot bet"), and non-linearity (similar to sensitivity to initial conditions, or the butterfly effect). Let us discuss these issues in more detail in Part II.



'I REFUSE TO PLAY BY-STANDER IN A STORY'

Kritika Kamra is glad her choices have helped build a perception where people don't come to her for bystander roles

Artists are never the sole decision-makers of anything, said Kritika Kamra, who is glad her choices have helped build a perception where people don't come to her for bystander roles.

Kamra earned a lot of praise for her role as the hassled daughter trying to meet a work deadline while dealing with a family crisis all in one day in the much-loved 'The Great Shamsuddin Family'. Now, she stars as a rich Parsi widow in filmmaker Nagraj Manjule's 'The Matka King', co-starring Vijay Varma.

Both Kamra and Varma are rank outsiders who have made a name for themselves without any backing.

Kamra said she is happy with how her career has unfolded, though she would like to be in the driver's seat more often. "Vijay recently said that he is carefully trying to build his filmography. I relate to that because I'm doing the same. We both feel that the cumulative sum of everything would be worth it. I've never had, at least not since my television years, any overnight success or one defining career moment. It has been small steps and multiple roles that have now shaped a certain perception," Kamra told PTI.

"Now, the work that comes my way is of a certain kind and quality because people see all my work

together and the diversity in it or just the fact that I refuse to play the bystander in a story. So, it's going to start reflecting on the things that come my way. But yes, the idea is to be in this for the long haul and to build something meaningful over time," she added.

Kamra, born in Bareilly, Uttar Pradesh, spent her early years in Madhya Pradesh and Delhi before moving to Mumbai after being spotted for a television role. She shot to fame with 'Kitani Mohabbat Hai' and its sequel 'Kuch Toh Log Kahenge'. The actress transitioned to OTT, featuring in shows such as 'Kaun Banegi Shikharwati', 'Gyaarah Gyaarah' and 'Bambai Meri Jaan' and the controversial series 'Tandav'.

Kamra said she has always tried to make better choices from whatever comes her way. "Actually, I'm still not in the driving seat.

I'm definitely trying to make better choices and choosing instinctively and also carefully from what I'm offered. But as an actor, you can never really be the sole decider of anything. So, it's a lot about the environment, what is being made currently, what's going to come your way and how the female characters are in those things. So, there are times when I have to really wait for a long time for something meaningful to come by," she said.

Playing Bani Ahmed in 'The Great Shamsuddin Family' was extremely fulfilling as an actor, but films like that are rarely made, she said, praising director Anusha Rizvi for her direction. "These kinds of films have almost got lost, so it was just bringing back this small film with a big heart and wonderfully written female characters. And to get to play the central part in an Anusha Rizvi film like this was absolutely a treat. I'm still not in a place where I'm bankrolling stuff or things that are being written specially for me. And I would like to get there," she said.

Kamra's character in 'Matka King' is again something that she hasn't done

before. She said she was eager to collaborate with Manjule as she has been a fan of the filmmaker's movies 'Fandry' and 'Sairat'.

"When I got to know that he's doing this show, I found out more about it and I auditioned for it, twice in fact and eventually got the part. And then getting to know that Vijay was a part of it. He's again somebody whose work I've followed and he's a really exciting actor to watch. It automatically made for a great team to collaborate with. I play a young Parsi woman from South Bombay. There's nothing in common that the character and I have and she becomes instrumental in bringing this game to her section of society and when the rich and famous start playing it," she said.

The actress said it took her a while to understand the game of 'Matka', a numbers-based gambling racket that was once rampant across India, as she didn't grow up in Mumbai. "Apparently, everybody in Maharashtra seems to know about it. It was a really big phenomenon in the 60s and 70s. It's a betting game where you draw cards and there's a combination of the total of certain digits that make for one opening number and one closing number. And then there are also other combinations that people bet on," Kamra said. PTI

HER CHARACTER IN 'MATKA KING' IS AGAIN SOMETHING THAT SHE HASN'T DONE BEFORE

'IT WAS A LOT OF FUN WITH THEM'



Paresh Rawal opened up about his reunion with Akshay Kumar and Priyadarshan in 'Bhooth Bangla'

BEDIKA

Paresh Rawal says it felt good to be back in the company of his favourite people - Priyadarshan and Akshay Kumar - for 'Bhooth Bangla', a film that reunited the trio after a long gap.

They have delivered several comedy hits in 'Garam Masala', 'Bhool Bhulaiyaa', 'Bhagam Bhag', 'Hera Pheri', 'Hungama' and 'Hungama 2'. Rawal is also reuniting with his 'Hera Pheri' co-star Tabu in this movie.

"It was a lot of fun to be back. You look forward to certain things in life. Sometimes, when you work with such good people, your journey is very good. This kind of company increases your haemoglobin. Your health improves," Rawal told PTI.

Shooting for 'Bhooth Bangla' was nostalgic for the actor as it was shot in Chomu Palace in Rajasthan, which was also the location of their 2007 hit 'Bhool Bhulaiyaa'.

But both the movies are completely different, said Rawal. "The interesting thing about this one is that there is going to be a marriage and the ghost is staying at the place. You can just imagine what will happen. I would say that this is a beautifully shot horror film. You haven't seen such a beautiful horror film," the actor added.

Praising Priyadarshan, Rawal said his friend is a producer-friendly director. "I have seen very few directors like him. If he says that he will finish the shoot in 10 days, then the shoot will be over in nine days. He is a director with that kind of clarity. It isn't a fair thing for such a person to stay away from Hindi films for so many years. But when I came to the sets, I enjoyed it a lot. The same atmosphere, the same spirit and the same camaraderie."

'Bhooth Bangla' was earlier set to release on April 10, but the makers decided to postpone the release following requests from exhibitors and distributors to provide an 'undisturbed window' to the movie at the box office, as 'Dhurandhar: The Revenge' was already playing in theatres. However, Rawal said it would be wrong to say that the release of the film was pushed because of 'Dhurandhar 2', which he enjoyed watching in theatres.

"There are different ways to look at it. It would be an injustice to both films to say that the release has been pushed because of 'Dhurandhar'. Ultimately, it's show business, so it should be treated like a business. In business, there is no foolhardiness because it will not benefit any of them. For example, 'Toxic' (release) has also gone up."

Yash starrer 'Toxic', which was earlier set for a clash with 'Dhurandhar 2' on March 19, is now slated to be released on June 4.

Rawal stars in a movie that has



'Sometimes, when you work with such good people, your journey is very good,' says the veteran actor

'ghosts' in its title, but he said he has never encountered such spirits in real life. "I don't believe in ghosts. There must be ghosts, but they haven't come into my life. Only a few humans have come into my life who are worse than ghosts," the actor said, joking that his formula to deal with them is to chant Hanuman Chalisa loudly.

A veteran of both theatre and movies, Rawal has shown his versatility in both serious and comedic roles. But that doesn't mean that the craft is to be ever taken lightly, he said. "If I get into a comedy role, it should be visible on my face and my performance. You have to take comedy seriously."

The trio of Kumar, Rawal and Priyadarshan aren't done yet as they are also working on the third part of the fan-favourite 'Hera Pheri' franchise. It is a project that has been in development for many years and suffered a huge setback after Rawal announced his exit through a post on social media in May last year. What followed was a lawsuit filed by Kumar, who is also the producer on the project through his company, 'Cape of Good Films'. But the actor returned to the project months later.

Did the controversy over 'Hera Pheri 3' affect his friendship with Kumar? Rawal said there is 'no bad blood' between them. "The issue was not about friendship. There was never any stain on it. But it happens. Sometimes, when you are so close, you tend to take things for granted. But there is no bad blood." AGENCIES

5 things that make 'The Boys' S5 impossible to ignore

The final season is our last chance to spend time with this dysfunctional family and see their stories reach a conclusion

After four power-packed seasons of superhero satire, jaw-dropping plot twists and unapologetically brutal social commentary, Prime Video's globally celebrated series, 'The Boys', is all set for its explosive final chapter. Now, with everything on the line, it's pushing every character to their breaking point in ways that fans have glued to their screens.

Here are five reasons why you must watch out for 'The Boys' Season 5:

Billy Butcher Vs Homelander: The cat-and-mouse game between them has been the beating heart of this series since day one. The stakes have never been higher and after years of near-misses and escalating hatred, their final confrontation promises to be unforgettable.

Answers for unresolved cliffhangers: Season 4 left us with some of the series' most shocking moments and a barrage of unanswered questions. Several fan theories have been doing the rounds on social media for months now, so the payoff for these dangling threads could redefine everything we thought we knew about the show's universe.

No holds barred storytelling: The best finales usually come with one thrilling advantage. The writers no longer need to save anyone for later. So, expect the gloves



to come off completely this season. Main characters won't have plot armour anymore and the show's already fearless approach will likely reach new heights in this final chapter.

Fan-favourite characters and surprise cameos: 'The Boys' has built a rich universe over four seasons, filled with memorable characters who've left their mark on the story. The final season promises the return of several fan favourites and the potential for unexpected appearances that will

delight longtime viewers.

Bidding farewell to unforgettable characters: Love them or hate them, the characters of 'The Boys' have become icons. From Hughie's journey from everyman to hero, to Starlight's evolution, to the complexity of characters like Kimiko, Frenchie and Mother's Milk, we've invested years into their arcs. And the final season is our last chance to spend time with this dysfunctional family and see their stories reach a conclusion. MPOST

